St. Francis
College for Women
Begumpet, Hyderabad-500016
(Autonomous & Affiliated to Osmania University)

A STUDY ON THE INFLUENCE OF DIGITAL CREATORS AND FINFLUENCERS ON FINANCIAL AWARENESS AND INVESTMENT BEHAVIOUR OF YOUNG ADULTS.

B.Com Dissertation

Submitted to St. Francis College for Women in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the award of the Degree of

Bachelors of Commerce

by

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March 2026

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CERTIFICATE

This is to certify that this bonafide project work titled **"A study on the influence of digital creators and finfluencers on financial awareness and investment behaviour of young adults"** has been carried out by **Tanvi Modani**, bearing the Roll no. **121323081052**, for the partial fulfillment as required for the award of **Bachelor degree** in Commerce (Accounting and Finance) from St. Francis College for Women, Begumpet in the academic year **2025 – 2026.**

Supervisor **Head of the Department**

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DECLARATION

I, Tanvi Modani, Roll Number 121323081052, a student of B.Com III Accounting and Finance, St. Francis College for Women, Begumpet, hereby declare that the Project Work titled **'A study on the influence of digital creators and finfluencers on financial awareness and investment behaviour of young adults'** is my own work and has been completed by me under the supervision of Dr. Singam Sunitha, Asst. Professor, Dept. of Commerce, St. Francis College for Women, Hyderabad.

I hereby declare that the results embodied in this work have not been submitted to any other Institution or University for an award of degree or diploma.

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ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

I would like to express my sincere gratitude to Dr. Uma Joseph, Principal of St. Francis College for Women, for providing the opportunity to undertake this project as part of my academic curriculum. I also extend my thanks to Dr. Savitha Sukumar, Head of the Department of Commerce & Management, for their support in facilitating this project.

I am deeply thankful to my project guide, Dr. Singam Sunitha, for helping me with this interesting project and providing me support, guidance and valuable insights to carry out my project successfully.

Lastly, I appreciate all the respondents whose valuable responses and co-operation contributed to the successful completion of this study.

TABLE OF CONTENT

LIST OF TABLES

3.17	Share of monthly income allocated or planned towards savings and investments.	43-44
3.18	Preferred type of financial content consumed online.	45-46
3.19	Time horizon considered while planning investments.	47
3.20	Level of diversification in personal investments.	48-49
3.21	Please indicate your preference or level in relation to the following financial aspects.	50-51
3.22	Please indicate your level of agreement with the following statements.	52-53
3.23	Please indicate the frequency of the following financial behaviours.	54-55

LIST OF GRAPHS

3.17	Share of monthly income allocated or planned towards savings and investments.	43-44
3.18	Preferred type of financial content consumed online.	45-46
3.19	Time horizon considered while planning investments.	47
3.20	Level of diversification in personal investments.	48-49
3.21	Please indicate your preference or level in relation to the following financial aspects.	50-51
3.22	Please indicate your level of agreement with the following statements.	52-53
3.23	Please indicate the frequency of the following financial behaviours.	54-55

CHAPTER - I

INTRODUCTION

CHAPTER 1: INTRODUCTION

1.1 DIGITALIZATION IN INDIA: The journey so far

India's journey toward digitalization has been captivating, fast-paced, and marked by major shifts in the way people live, work, and connect. What started as simple computer use in offices during the 1990s has today turned into a digitally driven lifestyle...from online payments to digital content creation.

The major shift began with the 1991 economic reforms, which opened India to global markets and led to the growth of the IT industry. In the early 2000s, wider internet access and increasing mobile phone usage further accelerated digital services. A significant boost came in 2015 with the launch of the Digital India campaign, which promoted internet usage, digital payments, and technology adoption across sectors, including rural areas.

As the technology improved and mobile internet became more affordable, especially after the entry of Jio, digital access started reaching even the smallest towns and villages. Suddenly, millions of Indians had smartphones and fast data at their fingertips. This opened the door to a new way of living…one where people could connect, learn, shop, and express themselves online like never before.

Apps like YouTube, Instagram, and earlier TikTok, gave regular people a chance to share their talent, opinions, and lifestyles with the world. And over time, they turned their passion into full-time careers. These influencers now earn money through brand deals, sponsorships, paid collaborations, and even their own startups.

Today, India has one of the largest and fastest-growing digital populations in the world. The influencer industry is booming, and behind the glamour of content lies a serious world of financial planning, income management, and smart investments- all made possible by the wave of digitalization.

Digitalization in India has not only improved access to technology, but it has also completely changed how individuals create value and generate income. With this shift, the lines between career, content, and commerce are increasingly blurred. As India moves deeper into the digital age, understanding the financial impact of this transformation, especially on new professions like influencing, becomes essential. This forms the foundation for further study.

1.2 FINANCIAL PLANNING - Components

Financial planning is the process of managing an individual's income, expenses, savings, and investments in a way that helps them achieve both short-term and long-term financial goals. For digital creators and influencers, whose income can often be irregular and variable, financial planning becomes even more important to maintain stability and growth.

- Key components in financial planning:

1. Income Management

For digital creators, income management is the base of sound financial planning. It includes tracking all the income sources, such as brand collaborations, advertisements, and affiliate marketing. Since earnings often fluctuate, budgeting monthly inflows helps maintain a steady cash flow.

2. Expense Planning

Expense planning helps creators separate personal and professional costs like production, travel, and marketing. Keeping track of recurring and one-time expenses prevents overspending, especially during high-income periods. Proper expense management ensures financial stability and transparency in operations.

3. Savings Planning

Savings are vital for financial security in an unpredictable career. Creators should regularly set aside at least three to six months of expenses. Prioritizing savings before making large purchases helps build a stable financial base.

4. Investment Planning

Investment planning allows influencers to grow their wealth systematically. They can explore options such as mutual funds, SIP's, fixed deposits, or equity investments, depending on their risk tolerance. Diversifying investments ensures balanced financial growth and supports both short-term goals, like equipment upgrades, and long-term goals, such as retirement or business expansion.

5. Tax Planning

Tax planning is crucial for creators earning through multiple income streams. Understanding tax obligations and maintaining proper income and expense records make filing easier. Legal deductions for business-related costs—like internet, equipment, and shoots—help reduce the overall tax burden.

6. **Insurance and Risk Management**

Creators face unique risks in the digital space, making insurance essential. Health, life, and professional liability insurance protect them from financial losses or legal disputes. Safeguarding intellectual property and content rights also helps protect their digital assets.

7. **Retirement and Future Planning**

Even though the creator economy can be short-lived, planning for the future is important. Building long-term wealth through passive income sources or new ventures ensures beyond their active career years. Early retirement planning helps secure financial independence in the long run.

1.3 VARIOUS OPTIONS PROVIDED BY BANKS OR FINANCIAL INSTITUTIONS

As content creation turns into a full-time profession, digital creators are increasingly relying on banks and financial institutions to support their financial journey. From managing irregular income to investing wisely, to planning taxes and securing loans, influencers today use a variety of financial products tailored for their needs.

1. **Savings and Deposit Schemes**

   - Regular Savings Account: For safe money storage and basic financial transactions.
   - Fixed Deposits (FDs): To earn guaranteed interest over a period with low risk.
   - Recurring Deposits (RDs): Ideal for setting aside a fixed amount monthly, encouraging disciplined saving.

2. **Investment Products**

   - Mutual Funds and SIPs: Offered through banks or asset management companies, helping creators grow wealth long-term.
   - Public Provident Fund (PPF): Government-backed, long-term savings with tax benefits.
   - Tax-saving Fixed Deposits: Provide tax deductions under Section 80C.

3. **Credit and Loan Service**s

   - Personal Loans: Quick access to funds for emergencies, equipment, upgrades, or content creation investments.
   - Credit Cards: Useful for managing cash flow, with regards and EMI options.
   - Overdraft Facilities: Help manage short-term gaps in income.

4. **Insurance Services**

   - Health Insurance: Protects against medical emergencies, essential for self-employed individuals.
   - Life Insurance: Offers financial security to family members in case of an untimely event.
   - Digital Asset Insurance (offered by select fintech companies): Protects equipment or content.

5. **Tax Planning Tools**

   - National Pension Scheme (NPS): Helps influencers plan retirement while saving on tax.
   - ELSS Mutual Fund: Equity-linked savings schemes with tax deductions.
   - Financial Advisory Services: Some banks offer guidance on tax-saving strategies and portfolio management.

6. **Business Banking Services**

   - Current Accounts: Suitable for influencers running registered businesses or operating as freelancers.
   - Payment Gateways & UPI Integration: Easy and fast payment collection from clients and brands.
   - Invoicing & Bookkeeping: Provided by some banks/fintech platforms for simple financial tracking.

7. **Digital Banking Services**

   - Mobile and Internet Banking: For 24/7 access to finances, especially helpful for creators on the move.
   - E-wallets and UPI: Seamless, real-time transfers for both personal and business use.
   - AI-based Budgeting Apps: Some banks now offer tools that help track spending and suggest savings.

8. **International Payment Services**

   - Influencers who work with global brands, platforms like YouTube, or freelance clients abroad often receive payments in foreign currency.
   - Banks offer international wire transfers, multi-currency accounts, and low-fee forex cards, making it easier for creators to receive, convert, and manage international payments safely.

1.4 INFLUENCER'S INCOME AND INVESTMENT PATTERNS

➢ **Sources of Income for Influencers**

Influencer income is diverse and dynamic, often coming from:

- Brand Sponsorships – Paid collaborations for product placement, reviews, or promotions
- Ad Revenue – Monetization through platforms like YouTube (AdSense), Instagram bonuses.
- Affiliate Marketing – Earnings through commission-based links.
- Merchandise & Product Sales – Some influencers launch their own products or clothing lines.
- Workshops / Online Courses – Educational content, tutorials, or skill-based training.
- Appearance / Events – Paid speaking gigs, hosting, or attending brand events.

Note: Unlike a salaried job, this income is often irregular, platform-dependent, and varies month to month.

➢ **Nature of Influencer Income**

- Unpredictable: Income depends on views, reach, and engagement—which can fluctuate.
- Multiple Streams: Most successful influencers diversify their income to stay financially stable.
- Global Exposure: Many receive international payments, introducing forex and tax implication.

1.5 SMART FINANCIAL PATTERNS

Even with inconsistent income, many top influencers follow plans well-structured financial plans:

I. **Budgeting & Income Control**

- Use budgeting tools like INDmoney, CRED, or a personal CA.
- Divide Income
  50% Lifestyle
  30% Investment
  20% Savings

II. **Strategic Investments**

- SIP in mutual funds for monthly discipline.
- Digital Gold, stocks, FDs for short-term & long-term growth.
- Property and studio space for content or rental income.
- Investing in startups.

III. **Tax & Compliance Planning**

- Maintain invoices for brand deals.
- Use business accounts to manage income.
- Hire CAs and advisors to avoid legal issues.

IV. **Lifestyle + Business Balance**

- Travel expenses are often brand-sponsored or shown as business trips.
- Many luxury purchases (gadgets, clothes) are claimed as content expenses.

❖ **The Secret Code They Crack**

Influencers don't just spend—they reinvest into their brand.

- Expensive trips? Often sponsored or tax-deductible for content creation.
- Designer shopping? It's part of image building, which attracts more brands.
- Financial planning allows them to spend, save, and invest – all at once.

THE INFLUENCER FINANCE FORMULA

Income	Spending	Investing	Security
Brand deals, ads, affiliates	Travel, wardrobe, content gear	SIPs,stocks, property	Insurance,tax planning

1.6 SIGNIFICANCE

The study on *"*Influencers, Income, and Investments: The New-Age Financial Planning of Digital Creators*"* is highly relevant to today's rapidly digitalizing economy. With the rise of social media platforms, a new category of earners—digital creators and influencers—has emerged, generating income through brand collaborations, sponsorships, and online ventures. However, due to the irregular, performance-based nature of these earnings, influencers often face challenges managing income stability, taxation, savings, and long-term financial planning. This study aims to understand how influencers manage their finances, make investment decisions, and plan for future security amidst fluctuating income streams. By exploring their financial behaviour, literacy, and awareness, the research provides insights into the financial discipline of a growing segment of self-employed youth. Moreover, the findings can assist financial institutions, policymakers, and aspiring influencers in developing better strategies, tools, and education programs that promote sustainable financial habits and long-term wealth creation in the creator economy.

1.7 SCOPE OF THE STUDY

- This study focuses on influencers who earn from platforms like Instagram, YouTube, & Podcasts.
- The scope contains influencer finance trends from the past 3-5 years, when the digital creators economy grew rapidly in India.
- It covers income sources, saving habits, investment patterns, and financial planning strategies of influencers.

1.8 OBJECTIVES

- The primary objective of this study is to analyze how digital content creators manage their finances, despite having irregular and unconventional income sources.
- To analyze the structure and diversity of income sources among social media influencers.
- To analyze the financial behavior and spending habits of influencers in the digital space.
- To understand the investment patterns followed by influencers and digital creators.
- To examine the role of banks and financial institutions in supporting influencer finance.

1.9 RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

- This project is based on secondary data:
- This research is descriptive and analytical research based on qualitative data.
- This research is based on Indian digital creators active on platforms like

a. Instagram & YouTube content

b. Blogs/Reels

c. Podcasts

1.10 LIMITATIONS OF THE STUDY

- This project is limited to Indian influencers, although a few global examples may be mentioned.
- Incomes and investment details of influencers are not publicly disclosed, so estimates may not show the full picture.

Due to the frequently changing digital economy, the financial patterns studied today may evolve quickly.

CHAPTER 2

REVIEW OF LITERATURE

CHAPTER 2: REVIEW OF LITERATURE

RESEARCH ARTICLES

Article 2.1

Title: Digital Finance and Social Media: A Bibliometric Analysis of Financial Influencers

Authors: T. Renuka & Usha Swaminathan
Journal: International Review of Management and Marketing

Year of Publication: 2025

Page no.: 45–58

The article "Digital Finance and Social Media: A Bibliometric Analysis of Financial Influencers" by T. Renuka and Usha Swaminathan (2025) explores how social media has become an important tool for spreading financial awareness and education. The study focuses on the rise of "financial influencers," commonly known as "finfluencers," who use platforms such as YouTube, Instagram, and Twitter to share financial knowledge and advice. The researchers aimed to understand how this area of study has developed over the years and what kind of research themes dominate it. Using data collected from Scopus and Web of Science, they analysed more than 150 published papers from 2015 to 2024 through bibliometric and content analysis methods. This helped them identify leading contributors, countries, and the most discussed ideas in this emerging field.

The study found that the topic of financial influencers is gaining strong attention worldwide, especially in countries like India, the United States, and the United Kingdom. Most of the existing research focuses on influencer credibility, audience trust, and how financial advice shared online affects followers' investment behaviour. The authors noted that social media has made financial education more accessible, especially for younger audiences, but also warned about the risks of misinformation and lack of regulation in this growing space.

The article concludes that financial influencers have become an influential part of modern finance by making complex topics easy to understand and encouraging better money management habits. However, since their advice is not always verified, the study stresses the need for regulation, ethical standards, and financial literacy programs to ensure responsible use of such content. This article is highly relevant to the present project as it provides a clear academic foundation for understanding how digital creators influence financial decision-making and highlights the importance of structured financial planning among online earners.

Article 2.2

Title: The Rise of Finfluencers in India: Evaluating their Impact, Regulatory Response, and Pathways for Advancement

Authors: Elizabeth Joey Henriques, Riva Ritinha Paes & Vembly Megna Colaco

Journal: International Journal of Information and Social Sciences

Year of Publication: 2025

Page no.: 112–128

A quiet but powerful movement has been reshaping India's financial culture — the emergence of "finfluencers," or financial influencers who combine money advice with digital creativity. In this 2024 study, N. Sharma and R. Iyer explore how this growing group of online educators has redefined the way Indians understand investments, savings, and budgeting. Instead of learning through traditional banking channels, audiences now turn to short videos, interactive posts, and relatable online personalities. The authors highlight how this transformation is not just social but economic, opening doors for young Indians to engage with finance in a more accessible and personalized way.

Unlike many earlier papers, this study dives deep into both the promise and pitfalls of the finfluencer wave. By analysing case studies, online engagement patterns, and regulatory interviews, Sharma and Iyer map out how digital creators influence financial behavior. They observe that while these influencers play an essential role in spreading awareness, their advice often blurs the line between education and promotion. The article also discusses SEBI's recent steps to draft influencer-specific guidelines, emphasizing the need for credibility, disclosure norms, and ethical marketing practices.

The study highlights finfluencers as powerful contributors to India's digital finance movement, helping simplify financial concepts and attract younger investors. However, it also cautions that their growing influence must be guided by transparency and ethical responsibility. With the right balance of creativity and credibility, finfluencers can evolve from online educators to lasting partners in advancing India's financial literacy and inclusion.

Article 2.3

Title: Social-Media Influence on the Investment Decisions Among the Young Adults in India

Authors: A. Priya & K. Subhashini

Journal: International Journal of Advanced Research in Commerce and Management Studies

Year of Publication: 2024

Page no.: 45–59

The article "Social Media Influence on the Investment Decisions Among the Young Adults in India" by A. Priya and K. Subhashini (2024) investigates how online platforms affect the investment behaviour of India's younger population. The authors emphasize that with the rise of digital communication, social media has become a major source of financial learning and motivation. The study highlights that platforms such as Instagram, YouTube, and Twitter play an active role in shaping opinions about savings, trading, and stock market participation. Using a descriptive research design, the authors collected data through structured questionnaires distributed among 200 young investors aged 18 to 30 from different parts of India.

The findings reveal that most respondents rely heavily on financial content from influencers before making investment choices. The visual appeal and relatability of such content make it easier for them to understand complex financial topics. However, the study also notes that emotional appeal and social validation on digital platforms often lead to impulsive decisions, especially in high-risk investments like cryptocurrencies and stocks. It was also found that young adults tend to trust influencers who show transparency and consistent financial success, even more than traditional financial advisors.

The authors conclude that social media has transformed the way young adults learn, evaluate, and act upon financial information. While it promotes financial inclusion and awareness, the lack of financial literacy and over-dependence on influencers can result in uninformed decisions. The study suggests that there is a need for greater awareness campaigns, financial education programs, and responsible influencer behaviour. This article supports the project by demonstrating how digital creators significantly shape financial attitudes and habits in modern India, reflecting both the potential and the pitfalls of this growing trend.

Article 2.4

Title: Micro-influencers and money: Assessing the impact of social Media micro-influencers on the personal financial behaviours of Young Adults

Authors: D. Verma & L. Thomas (2024)

Journal: Journal of Contemporary Finance and Communication Studies

Year of Publication: 2024

Page no.: 54–70

The article by D. Verma and L. Thomas (2024) studies the growing influence of micro-influencers on the personal financial behaviour of young adults in India. These influencers, often with smaller but highly engaged audiences, are becoming trusted voices for financial learning on platforms like Instagram and YouTube. Unlike large-scale influencers who appeal to the masses, micro-influencers create a sense of community and authenticity by sharing their own money management experiences and simple financial advice. The authors designed a survey-based study covering 300 participants between the ages of 18 and 25 from metropolitan regions to explore how exposure to such content affects financial habits, decision-making, and awareness levels.

The study reveals that micro-influencers have made financial topics more understandable and appealing to the younger generation. Many respondents shared that they began saving regularly or investing in SIPs after following relatable content creators. The paper notes that authenticity and consistency are key to building trust with followers. However, it also warns that the lack of formal financial expertise among influencers can sometimes lead to inaccurate or incomplete information. Peer validation and online engagement further amplify this influence, often guiding financial behaviour in subtle ways.

The authors conclude that micro-influencers play a meaningful role in promoting financial awareness at a grassroots level. Their approachable style encourages young people to take early financial actions and develop better money habits. The study recommends that credible micro-influencers collaborate with financial institutions to ensure reliable guidance. This article strengthens the project by highlighting how smaller, trustworthy creators can shape financial learning through connection and authenticity rather than scale.

Article 2.5

Title: The Role of Content Creators on Cryptocurrency Investment Decisions in Gen-Z Mediated by Digital Financial Literacy

Authors: Trevina, V. & Kohardinata, C.

Journal: Journal of Research & Analysis in Knowledge (JRAK)

Year of Publication: 2024

Page no.: 2

In a world where social media trends often shape financial behaviour, Trevina and Kohardinata (2024) explore how digital content creators influence cryptocurrency investment choices among Gen-Z individuals. The study examines the psychological and informational impact of financial influencers, focusing on how digital financial literacy acts as a bridge between influencer exposure and investment decisions. Drawing on survey data collected from young adults aged 18–25, the authors apply a quantitative analytical framework to understand how trust, perceived credibility, and financial awareness interact within the fast-evolving crypto ecosystem.

The research finds that Gen-Z investors tend to rely heavily on influencers for crypto-related insights, often valuing relatability over traditional financial expertise. However, the mediating role of digital financial literacy emerges as crucial — individuals with higher literacy levels are better able to verify, interpret, and apply the financial advice they encounter online. Those lacking this literacy are more prone to impulsive investments driven by social hype or influencer endorsements. The study emphasizes that influencer-driven finance, while powerful, becomes truly effective only when paired with critical understanding and education.

Rather than dismissing influencers as mere trendsetters, Trevina and Kohardinata position them as potential partners in financial education, capable of making complex financial topics accessible to a younger audience. They advocate for collaborations between credible creators, financial institutions, and educational platforms to promote responsible investing. The study ultimately broadens the narrative — showing that in the age of digital finance, empowerment lies not just in visibility, but in literacy.

Article 2.6

Title: Digital Financial Literacy and Its Impact on Financial Decision-Making of Women: Evidence from India

Authors: Deepak Mishra, Naveen Agarwal, Sanawi Sharahiley & Vinay Kandpal

Journal: Journal of Finance and Economics Development

Year of Publication: 2024

Page no.: 10

Deepak Mishra and colleagues (2024) present an insightful exploration of how digital financial literacy (DFL) has transformed women's ability to make informed financial decisions in India. The study examines the growing intersection of technology, accessibility, and empowerment, focusing on how digital platforms and fintech tools are bridging long-standing gender gaps in financial inclusion. Using structured questionnaires and a descriptive research design, the authors assess factors such as financial attitude, self-efficacy, and access to digital banking across urban and semi-urban regions.

The results reveal that women with higher digital financial literacy demonstrate stronger financial confidence and greater participation in investment and savings activities. Increased exposure to digital payment systems, online banking, and educational financial content has encouraged women to take active control over personal and household finances. However, the research also notes barriers — including limited access to digital infrastructure in rural areas and cultural norms that still discourage independent decision-making. The study concludes that while technology has accelerated progress, true inclusivity requires continuous education and awareness.

This study captures a quiet revolution — one driven not by policy alone, but by knowledge in women's own hands. Mishra and his co-authors emphasize that the future of financial empowerment depends on ensuring every woman, regardless of geography or background, has both access to digital tools and the confidence to use them. By linking literacy with agency, the paper highlights a profound truth: when women understand money, they don't just manage it — they redefine its purpose.

Article 2.7

Title: “Rich-Get-Richer”? Analyzing Content Creator Earnings Across Large Social Media Platforms

Authors: A. Nair & P. Khanna

Journal: Journal of Digital Economics

Year of Publication: 2024

Page no.: 120–138

A. Nair and P. Khanna (2024) explore the growing financial inequality within the creator economy, questioning whether the digital space has truly democratized opportunity or merely mirrored traditional hierarchies. Their research draws on data from major social platforms such as YouTube, Instagram, and TikTok to map how income distribution varies between top-tier creators and emerging ones. Using a mixed-method approach, combining statistical analysis with qualitative interviews, the study provides a layered understanding of how visibility, engagement algorithms, and brand collaborations affect earning potential.

The findings reveal a clear skew in revenue patterns — a small fraction of influencers capture the majority of brand deals and ad-based income, while the vast majority struggle to achieve financial consistency. Algorithmic favouring of already popular creators and unequal access to monetization tools contribute to this imbalance. The study also highlights how platform policies and marketing networks often reinforce this “rich-get-richer” cycle, leaving smaller creators dependent on unpredictable sponsorships or affiliate links.

Rather than offering a purely pessimistic outlook, the study encourages a call for systemic recalibration — suggesting that platforms, regulators, and creators themselves share responsibility in creating fairer financial ecosystems. It highlights the need for systemic balance in the digital economy through transparent algorithms, fairer brand collaborations, and inclusive revenue-sharing frameworks. They also emphasize financial literacy and diversification of income sources to help creators achieve long-term security. The study ultimately reminds readers that while social media has democratized visibility, financial success remains concentrated in the hands of a few, demanding structural change for a truly equitable creator ecosystem.

Article 2.8

Title: The Impact of Social Media Influencers on Personal Finance and Investment Decisions

Authors: R. Mehta & S. Chatterjee

Journal: Journal of Digital Marketing and Financial Behavior

Year of Publication: 2023

Page no.: 112–128

Over the past few years, the internet has changed the way individuals learn about and manage their money, and this article by R. Mehta and S. Chatterjee (2023) captures that shift vividly. The researchers explore how financial influencers on platforms like YouTube, Instagram, and X (formerly Twitter) shape people's financial opinions and daily decisions. Instead of relying on conventional financial advisors, audiences are increasingly turning to relatable online figures who share personal experiences and easy-to-follow advice. The study combines both qualitative and quantitative research methods — a survey of 250 social media users and interviews with 20 financial influencers — to gain insights from both the creator and consumer sides of the digital finance ecosystem.

According to the authors, the influence of such content creators is both positive and complex. Many participants admitted they began investing or saving only after encountering influencer-led financial content. For instance, several respondents said they started SIPs, mutual fund accounts, or side investments based on what they learned online. Yet, the research also points out a concerning trend: a portion of viewers make quick, emotionally driven financial choices without verifying facts, simply trusting influencers' claims. This underlines the double-edged nature of digital influence — it simplifies financial literacy but can also spread half-baked information.

The article concludes that social media has redefined the concept of financial mentorship. Influencers today act as informal educators, especially for young adults who are new to finance. However, the study stresses the need for ethical content creation and regulatory awareness to ensure credibility. Mehta and Chatterjee argue that social media should be seen as a supplementary learning space rather than a replacement for professional advice. This research connects closely to the project's theme, as it captures how influencer culture is not just reshaping financial awareness but also altering investment behaviour in India's emerging digital economy.

Article 2.9

Title: Short-Term Earnings from Social Media vs Long-Term Career Growth

Authors: P. Nair & V. Kapoor (2023)

Journal: International Review of Digital Economics and Work Culture

Year of Publication: 2023

Page no.: 93–107

It's fascinating how social media has created an entirely new path to fame and income — but the question that many young creators face is whether this digital success translates into lasting growth. This study by P. Nair and V. Kapoor (2023) explores that very dilemma, comparing the short-term financial rewards gained through online content creation with the long-term stability and professional development that traditional careers usually offer. The authors examine how influencers, especially in finance and lifestyle sectors, manage their sudden rise in income and whether they adopt sustainable planning to maintain it beyond their online popularity.

Using a combination of case studies and survey-based data, the research looks at 150 digital creators across India who earn through brand collaborations, ad revenue, and affiliate marketing. The findings show that while many creators enjoy high earnings in the short run, only a fraction translates those gains into meaningful long-term investments or career diversification. A major challenge highlighted in the paper is the lack of financial discipline and risk awareness among younger influencers. Several respondents admitted that fluctuating income and irregular work opportunities make it hard to maintain savings or plan for retirement.

The authors conclude that digital careers can be financially rewarding but require the same strategic approach as any other profession. They stress the importance of financial literacy, budgeting, and diversified investments to balance short-term success with long-term security. The study recommends that influencers treat their earnings like a business, with proper tax planning, savings, and reinvestment strategies. This article is especially relevant to the project as it highlights the gap between income generation and sustainable financial growth — a key issue in understanding how digital creators handle money beyond their online fame.

Article 2.10

Title: Financial literacy, robo-advising, and the demand for human financial advice

Authors: K. Mehta & A. Roy

Journal: Indian Journal of Behavioral Finance

Year of Publication: 2023

Page no.: 88–103

K. Mehta and A. Roy (2023) investigate how the growing digitalization of financial services is influencing investor preferences between human advisors and algorithm-based platforms. The study focuses on the role of financial literacy in determining whether investors trust automated tools such as robo-advisors or rely on traditional personal guidance. Drawing insights from a survey of 250 urban investors, the authors analyse patterns in digital adoption and confidence in self-managed financial planning.

The research finds that individuals with stronger financial knowledge are more open to experimenting with robo-advisors due to their convenience and affordability. However, investors continue to associate human advisors with trust, emotional reassurance, and nuanced financial judgment — factors that machines cannot replicate. The study underlines the significance of a balanced approach that merges technological efficiency with human insight.

Rather than treating technology as a replacement, Mehta and Roy suggest a collaborative future where digital advisory tools and human expertise work hand in hand. Such integration could democratize access to financial advice while retaining the personal dimension crucial for complex financial decisions. This perspective enriches the broader discussion on digital finance by showing how innovation can coexist with traditional wisdom in shaping informed, confident investors.

CHAPTER - III

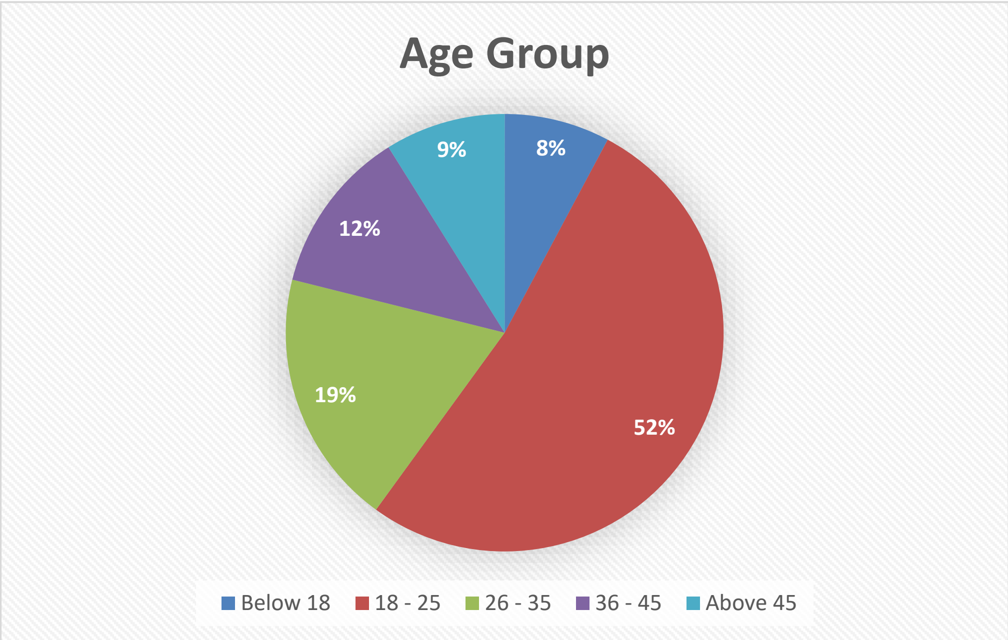
DATA ANALYSIS AND INTERPRETATION

CHAPTER 3: DATA ANALYSIS AND INTERPRETATION

Age Group of Respondents

Table and Chart 3.1

Particulars (Age)	Percentage
Below 18	8%
18 - 25	52%
26 - 35	19%
36 - 45	12%
Above 45	9%
Total	100%



Source: Primary Data

Interpretation

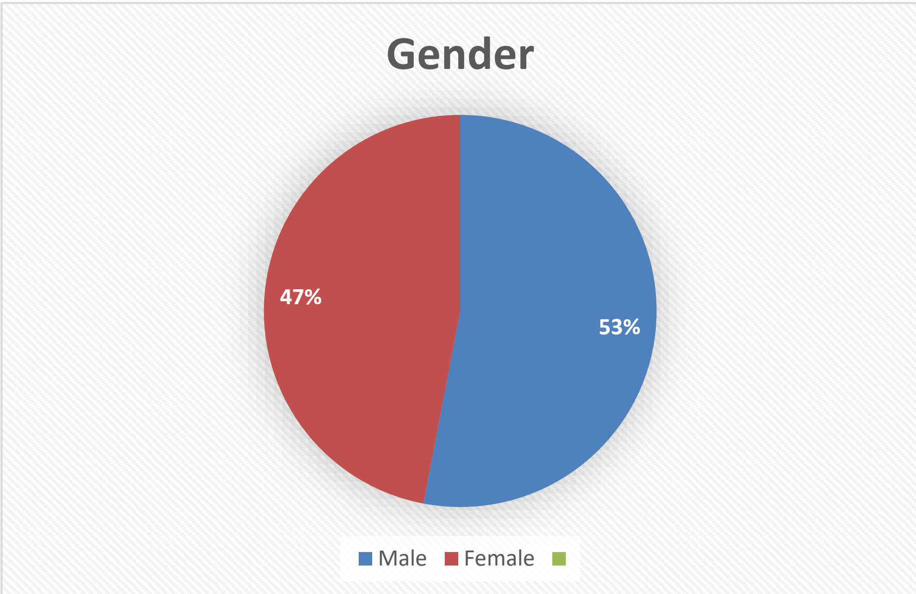
The table and pie chart present the age distribution of the respondents. The majority of respondents fall within the 18 to 25 age group at 52%, indicating that young adults form the primary segment of the sample. The 26 to 35 age group accounts for 19%, followed by 36 to 45 at 12%. Respondents below 18 represent 8%, while those above 45 account for 9%.

This distribution shows that the study is largely centered on young adults, which aligns with examining the influence of digital creators on financial awareness and investment behaviour among this demographic. Respondents from other age groups add diversity to the sample and provide broader insights into how digital financial content is perceived at different life stages.

Gender Profile of Respondents

Table and Chart 3.2

Gender	Percentage
Male	53%
Female	47%
Total	100%



Source: Primary Data

Interpretation

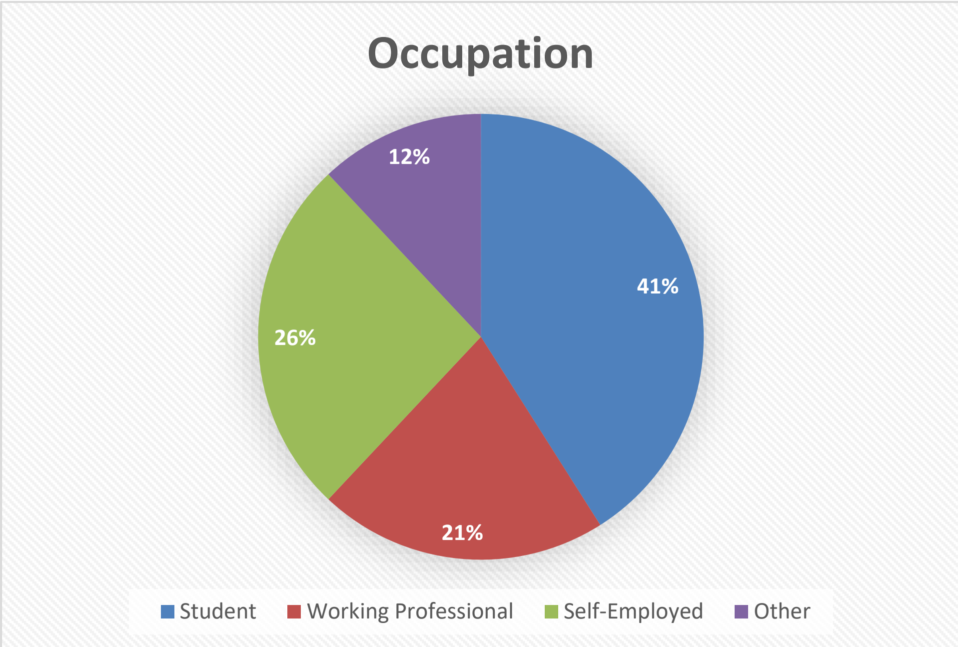
The table and pie chart show the gender distribution of the respondents. Males account for 53% of the sample, while females represent 47%. This indicates a fairly balanced representation of both genders in the study.

The near-equal distribution strengthens the reliability of the findings, as it allows financial awareness and behavioural patterns to be analysed without significant gender bias. From a financial perspective, balanced gender participation supports a more comprehensive understanding of how digital financial content influences saving, spending, and investment behaviour across different demographic groups.

Occupation of Respondents

Table and Chart 3.3

Occupation	Percentage
Student	41%
Working Professional	21%
Self-Employed	26%
Other	12%
Total	100%



Source: Primary Data

Interpretation

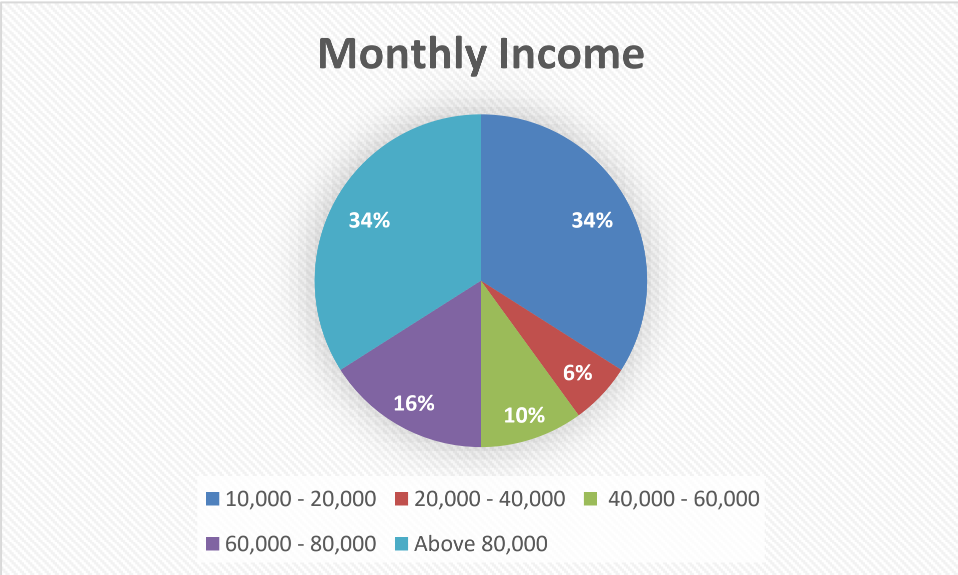
The table and pie chart present the occupational distribution of the respondents. Students form the largest group at 41%, followed by self-employed individuals at 26% and working professionals at 21%. The remaining 12% fall under other occupational categories.

This distribution indicates that a significant portion of the sample consists of young individuals who are either currently studying or in the early stages of their careers. The presence of self-employed and working professionals also adds diversity to the sample, allowing the study to capture financial behaviour across different employment statuses. From a financial perspective, this varied occupational background supports a broader analysis of saving, spending, and investment patterns among individuals with different income structures and financial responsibilities.

Monthly Income of Respondents

Table and Chart 3.4

Monthly Income	Percentage
10,000 - 20,000	34%
20,000 - 40,000	6%
40,000 - 60,000	10%
60,000 - 80,000	16%
Above 80,000	34%
Total	100%



Source: Primary Data

Interpretation

The table and pie chart present the monthly income distribution of the respondents. The highest proportions are observed in the income ranges of 10,000 to 20,000 and above 80,000, each accounting for 34 percent of the total respondents. This indicates that the sample consists of individuals from both lower and higher income brackets in nearly equal proportions.

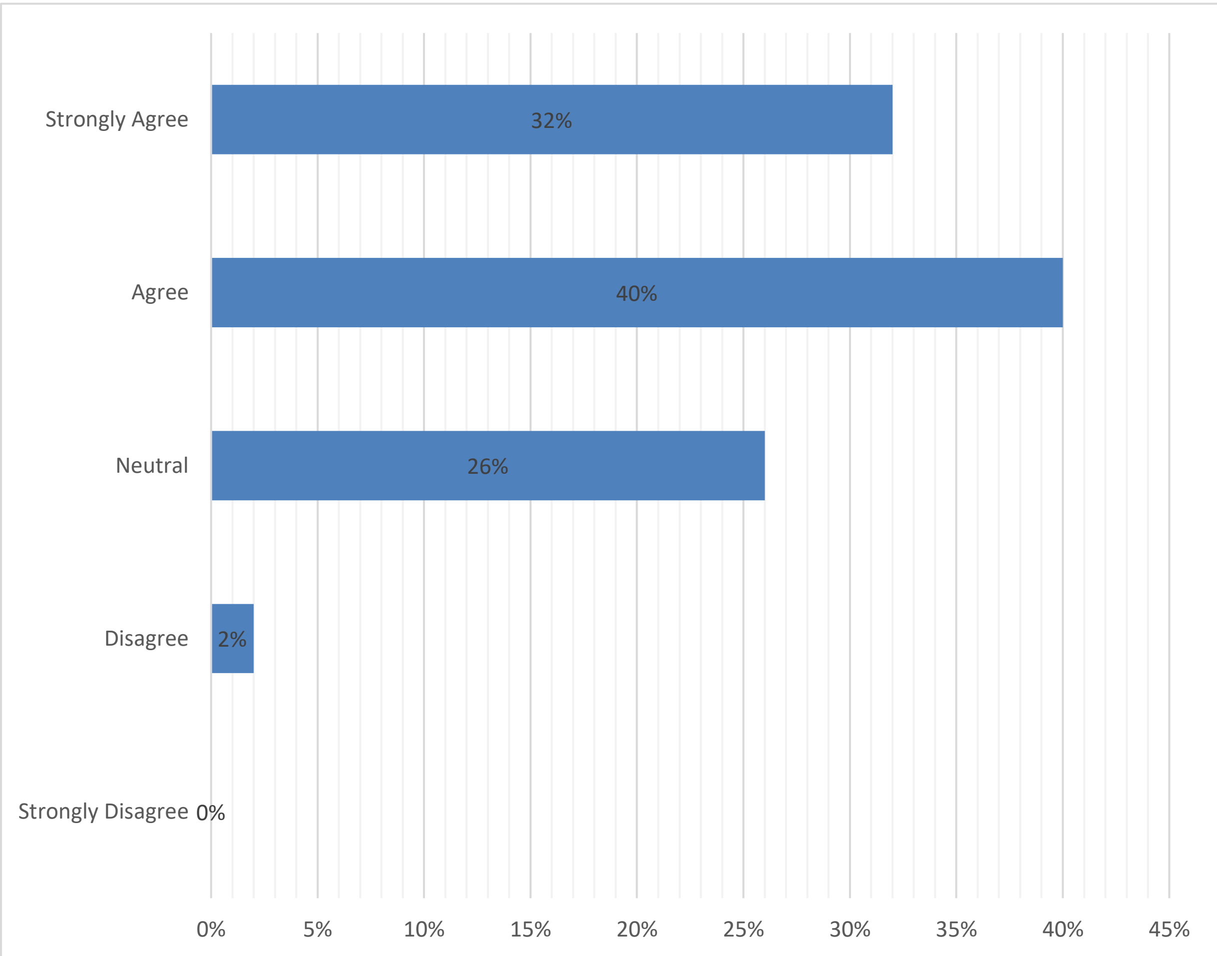
A smaller percentage of respondents fall within the 60,000 to 80,000 range at 16 percent, followed by 40,000 to 60,000 at 10 percent. The 20,000 to 40,000 income group represents the lowest share at 6 percent. The distribution reflects a varied income profile among respondents, allowing the study to capture financial behaviour across different earning levels.

From a financial perspective, the varied income distribution strengthens the study by allowing analysis of saving, spending, and investment behavior across different earning levels. This diversity provides a more balanced understanding of the influence of digital financial content.

1. Social media content influences financial awareness more effectively than traditional learning sources.

Table and Chart 3.5

Strongly Disagree	0%
Disagree	2%
Neutral	26%
Agree	40%
Strongly Agree	32%
Total	100%



Source: Primary Data

Interpretation

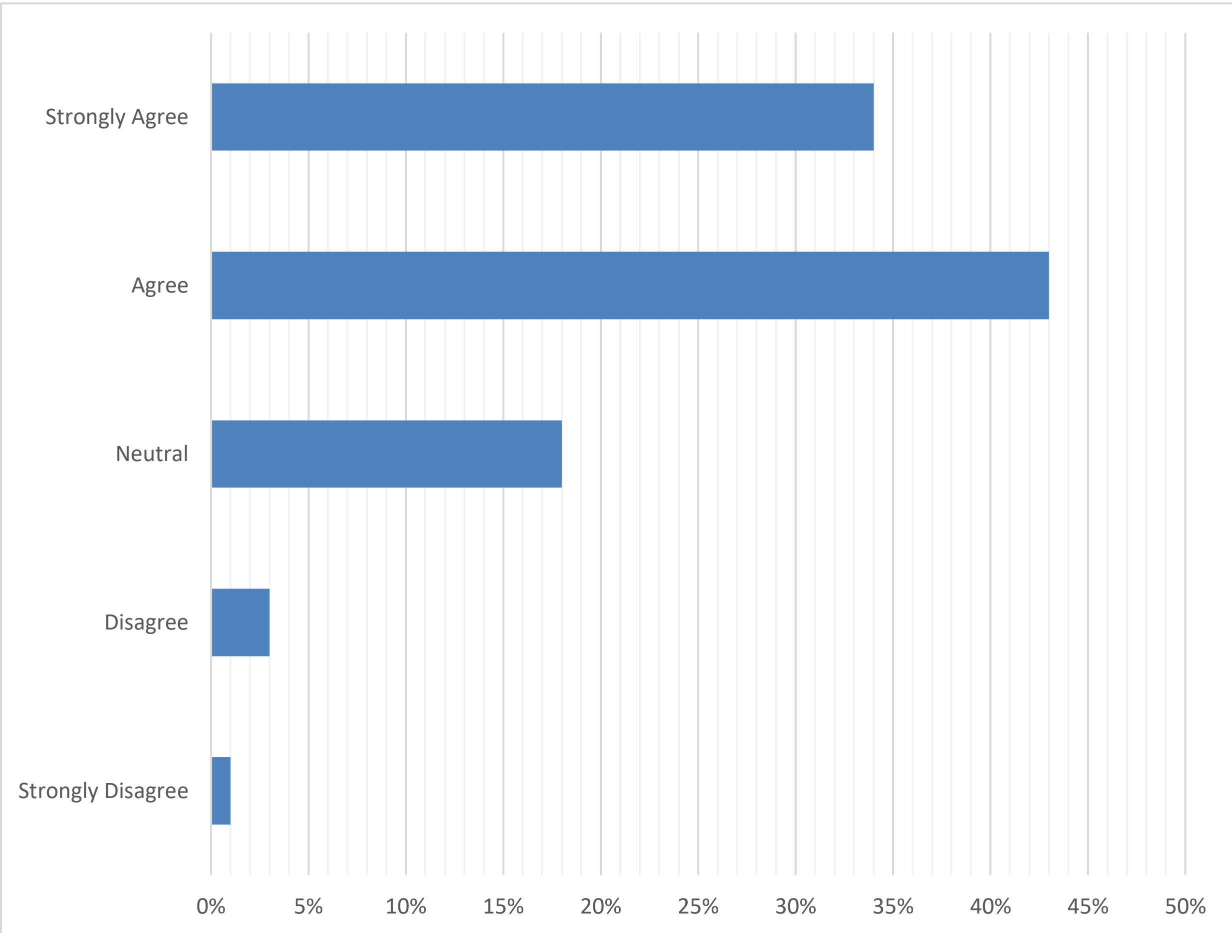
The table and chart present the level of agreement with the statement that social media content influences financial awareness more effectively than traditional learning sources. A majority of respondents agree at 40 percent and strongly agree at 32 percent, while 26 percent remain neutral. Only 2 percent disagree and none strongly disagree. This indicates that a significant proportion of respondents perceive social media as a more effective medium for enhancing financial awareness compared to conventional sources.

The strong positive responses suggest that digital platforms are increasingly viewed as accessible and impactful channels for financial education. From a financial perspective, the findings highlight the growing importance of digital content in shaping financial knowledge and awareness among young adults, while also indicating a gradual shift in preference toward more interactive and easily accessible learning formats.

2. Finfluencers simplify complex financial topics for young audience.

Table and Chart 3.6

Strongly Disagree	1%
Disagree	3%
Neutral	18%
Agree	43%
Strongly Agree	34%
Total	100%



Source: Primary Data

Interpretation

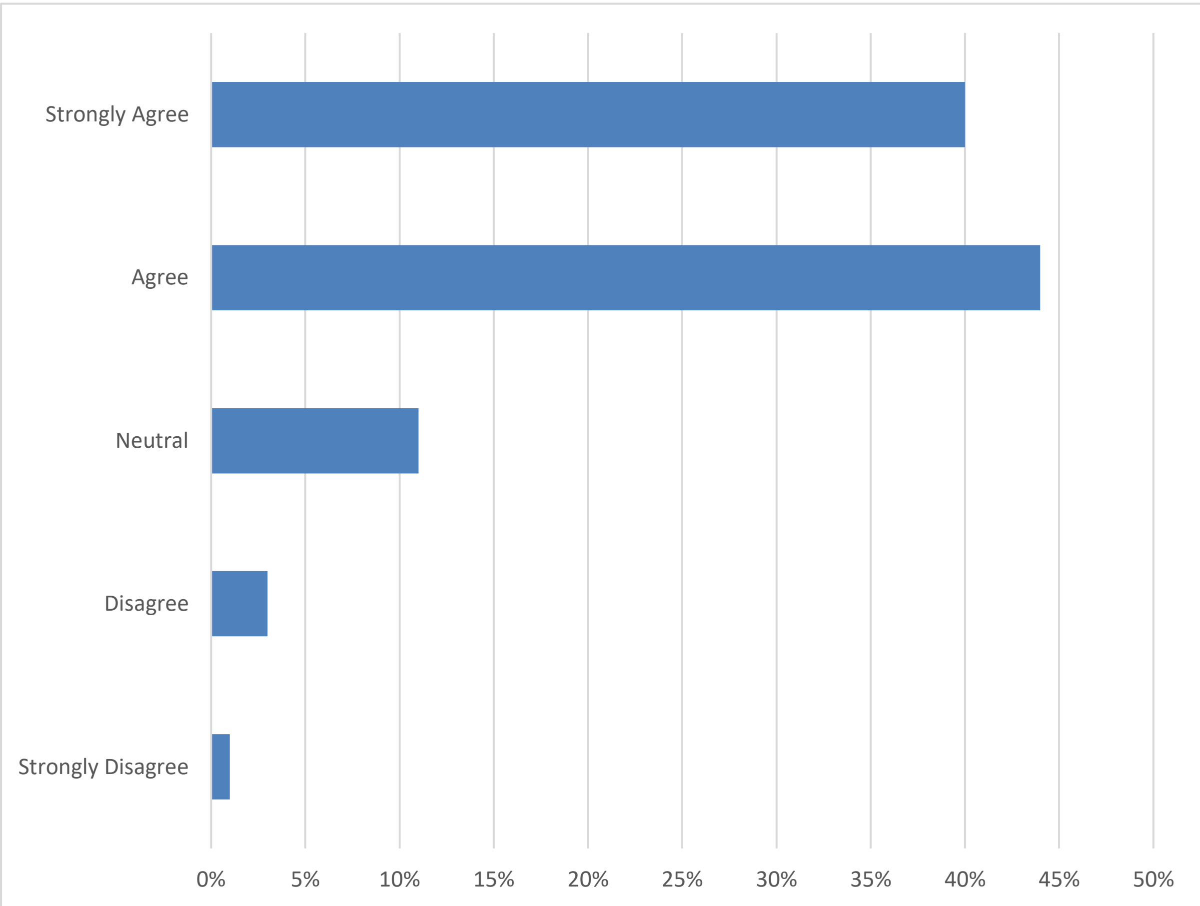
The bar chart evaluates the agreement that influencers simplify complex financial topics for young audiences. A clear majority of respondents believe that finfluencers simplify complex financial topics for young audiences. Agree accounts for 43% and strongly agree for 34%, while 18% remain neutral. Only 3% disagree, and 1% strongly disagree, showing very limited negative perception. A strong majority of 82% sees influencers breaking down tough concepts effectively.

Simplifying concepts such as investing, budgeting, or risk management can increase financial awareness and confidence among young adults. The moderate neutral responses suggest that while many find such content helpful, some may still rely on other sources for a deeper understanding. Overall, the findings highlight the role of finfluencers in making financial knowledge more accessible and practical for respondents.

3. Finfluencers encourage early savings and investment habits.

Table and Chart 3.7

Strongly Disagree	1%
Disagree	3%
Neutral	11%
Agree	44%
Strongly Agree	40%
Total	100%



Source: Primary Data

Interpretation

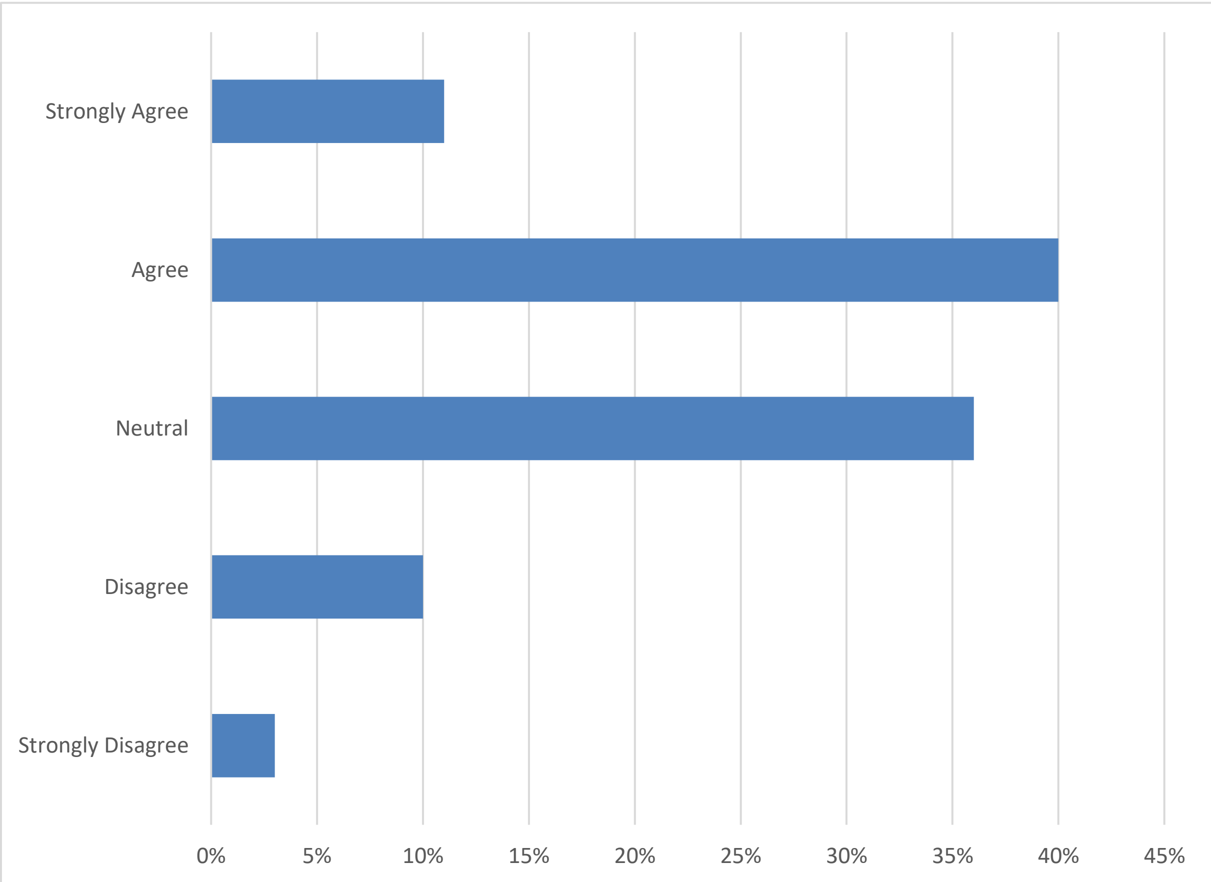
A strong positive response is visible regarding the role of finfluencers in encouraging early savings and investment habits. Agree accounts for 44% and strongly agree for 40%, while only 3% disagree and 1% strongly disagree. Neutral responses stand at 11%. This clearly shows that a large majority of respondents believe finfluencers play an active role in motivating young adults to start managing their money at an early stage.

An overwhelming 81 percent either agree or strongly agree on this encouragement. It indicates influencers powerfully motivate young adults toward timely financial discipline, directly supporting my objectives on their behavioral impact. Despite creators' own income instability, they promote proactive saving, fostering patterns that complement bank products and enhance overall awareness.

4. Digital creators have influenced my investment decisions directly or indirectly.

Table and Chart 3.8

Strongly Disagree	3%
Disagree	10%
Neutral	36%
Agree	40%
Strongly Agree	11%
Total	100%



Source: Primary Data

Interpretation

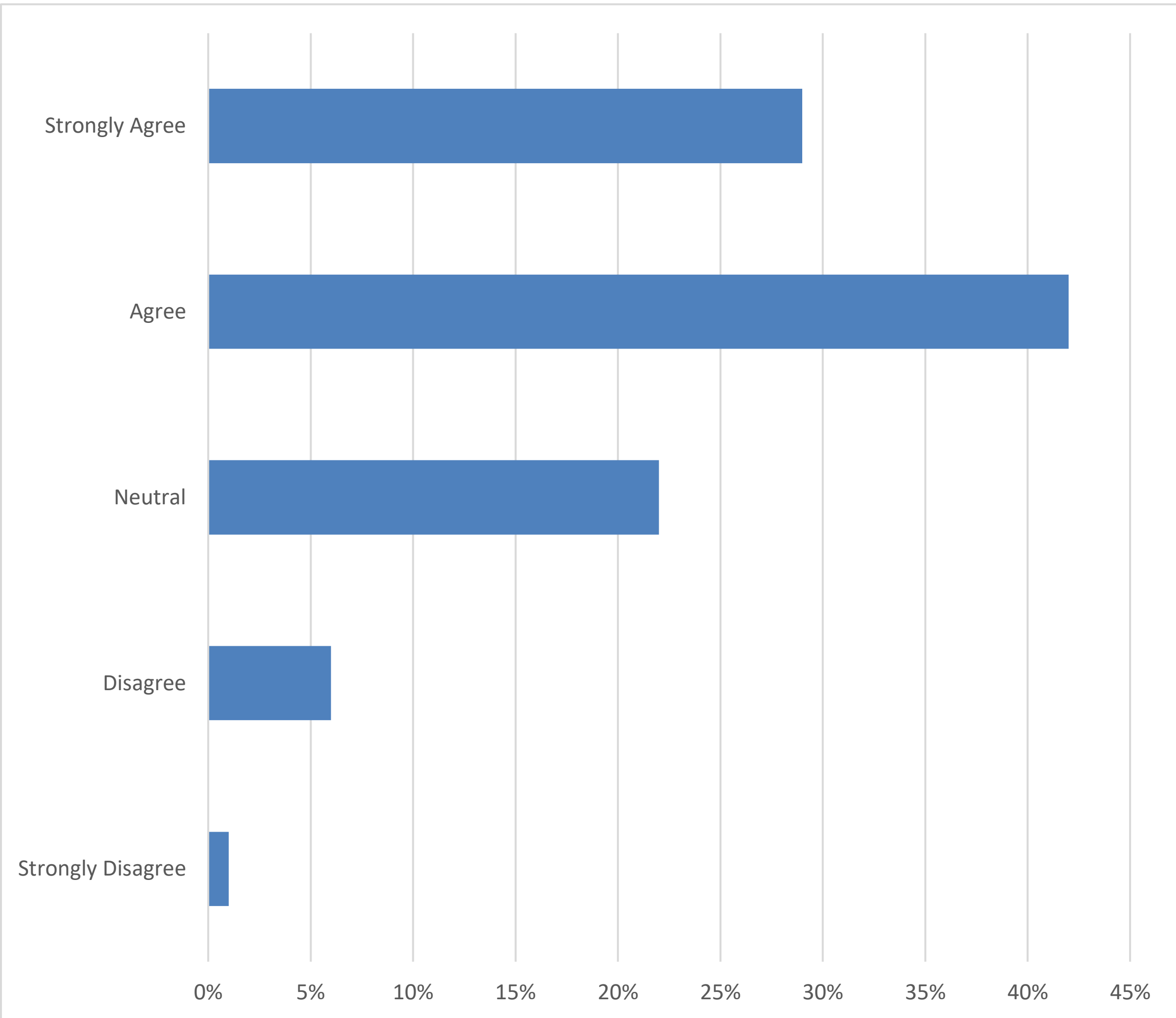
The table and chart show the level of agreement that digital creators have influenced investment decisions either directly or indirectly. A majority of respondents agree at 40%, followed by 11% who strongly agree, while 36% remain neutral. In contrast, 10% disagree, and 3% strongly disagree. This indicates that more than half of the respondents acknowledge some level of influence from digital creators on their investment decisions.

The relatively high neutral response shows that although many respondents recognise some influence, it may not always be direct or clearly realised. Investment decisions are usually based on several factors such as risk understanding, financial knowledge, and personal goals. This suggests that digital creators may not be the main decision-makers, but they do contribute to shaping investment awareness and preferences. Overall, digital financial content influences investment behaviour among young adults, though the impact varies across individuals.

5. Content created on social media platforms affects spending and saving behaviour.

Table and Chart 3.9

Strongly Disagree	1%
Disagree	6%
Neutral	22%
Agree	42%
Strongly Agree	29%
Total	100%



Source: Primary Data

Interpretation

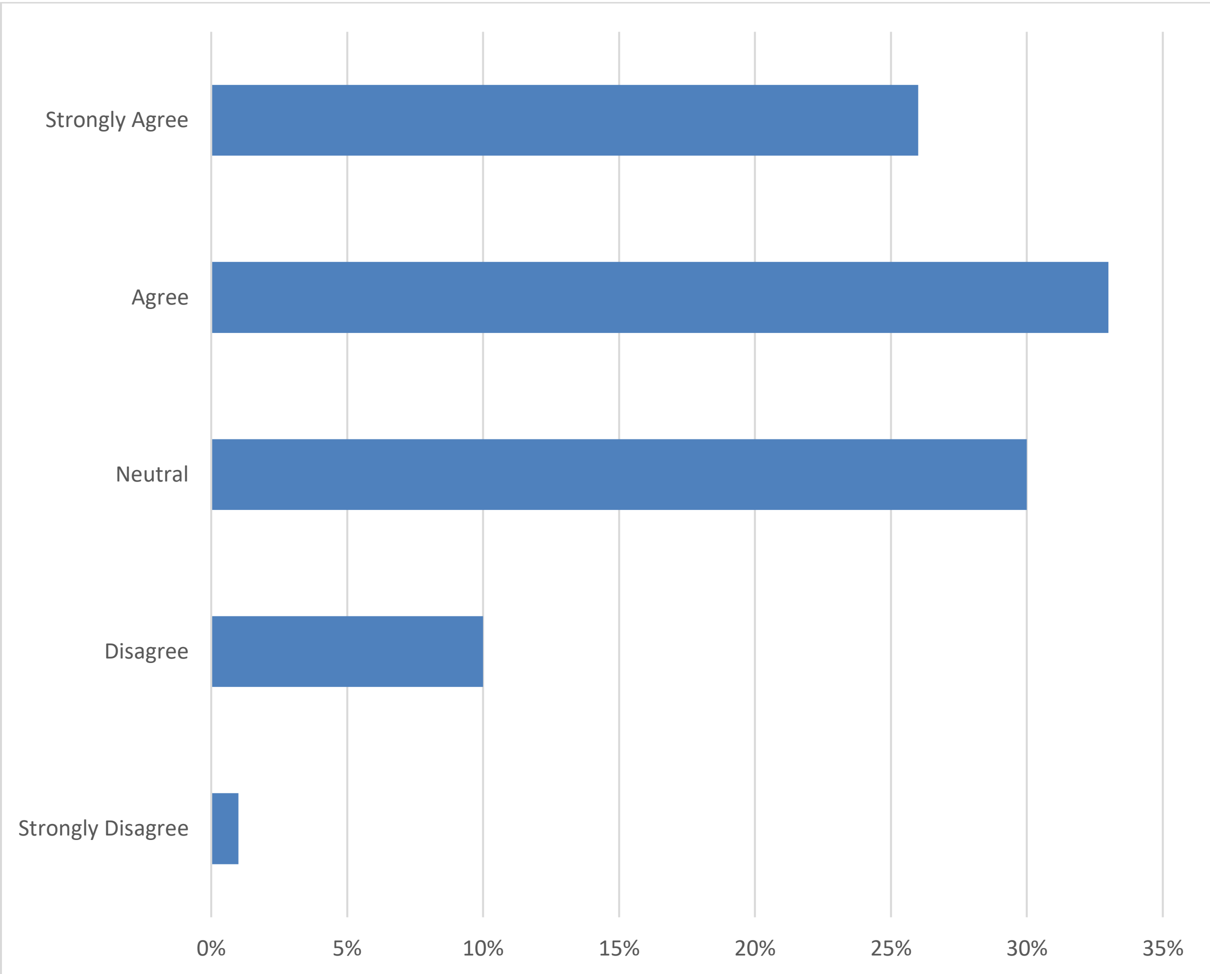
The bar chart assesses agreement that content created on social media platforms affects spending and behavior. A majority of respondents strongly agree at 50%, followed by 30% who agree, while 16% remain neutral. Only 3% disagree and 1% strongly disagree. This indicates that a large proportion of respondents perceive digital creators as influential in shaping everyday habits and spending choices.

The strong positive responses show that digital creators influence more than just entertainment. Their content affects lifestyle choices, which can directly impact spending habits. When spending patterns change, saving capacity and investment decisions are also affected. The very low level of disagreement suggests that most respondents accept this influence. Overall, this shows that digital creators indirectly shape financial behaviour through the way they influence daily lifestyle choices.

6. Engagement with digital creators feels more relatable than interaction with formal financial institutions.

Table and Chart 3.10

Strongly Disagree	1%
Disagree	10%
Neutral	30%
Agree	33%
Strongly Agree	26%
Total	100%



Source: Primary Data

Interpretation

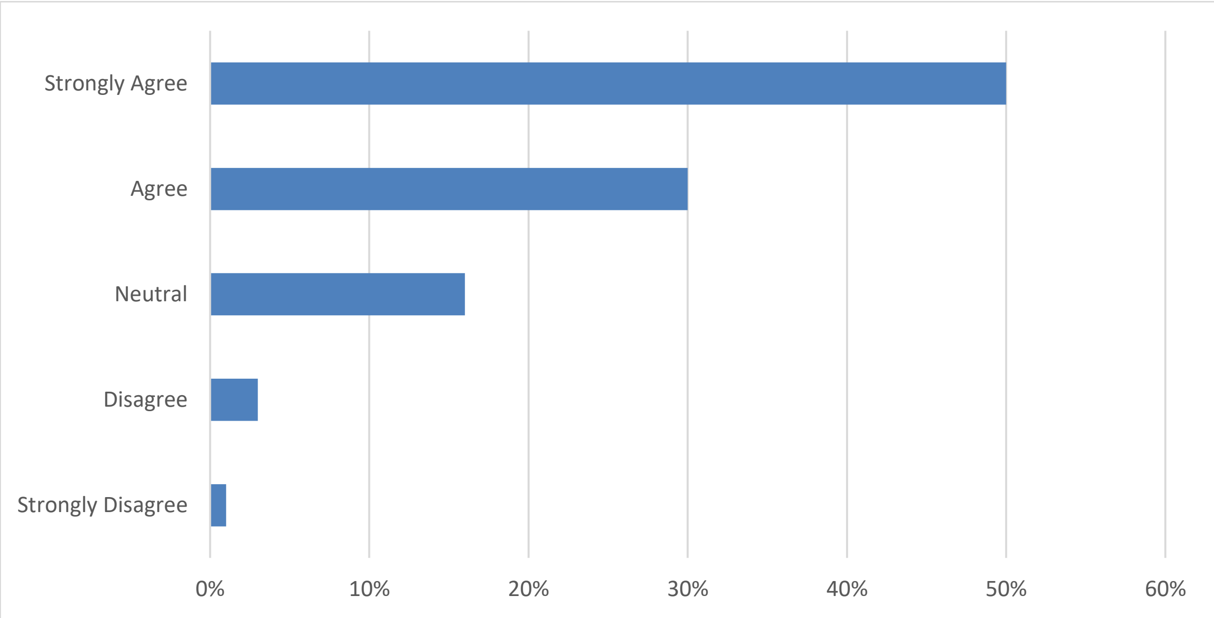
The table and chart show the level of agreement that engagement with digital creators feels more relatable than interaction with formal financial institutions. A majority of respondents agree at 33% and strongly agree at 26%, while 30% remain neutral. In contrast, 10% disagree and only 1% strongly disagree. This indicates that more than half of the respondents perceive digital creators as more relatable compared to traditional financial institutions.

From a financial point of view, relatability can increase comfort in seeking and accepting financial information. When financial concepts are explained in a simple and practical manner, young adults may feel more confident in applying them. The low level of disagreement suggests that formal institutions may be perceived as less engaging, which highlights the growing importance of communication style in financial awareness and decision-making.

7. Digital creators play a significant role in shaping lifestyle and consumption patterns among young adults.

Table and Chart 3.11

Strongly Disagree	1%
Disagree	3%
Neutral	16%
Agree	30%
Strongly Agree	50%
Total	100%



Source: Primary Data

Interpretation

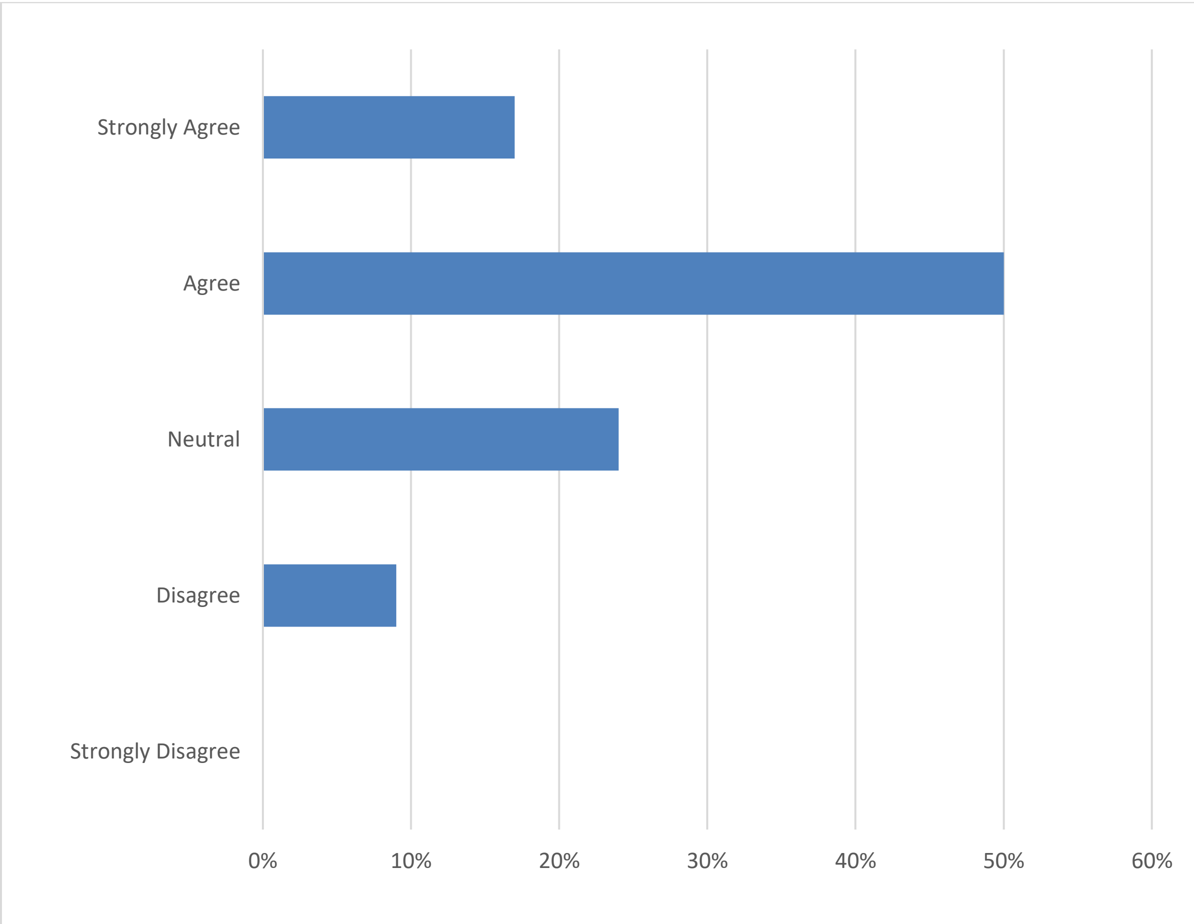
The table and chart show the level of agreement that digital creators play a significant role in shaping lifestyle and consumption patterns among young adults. A majority of respondents strongly agree at 50%, followed by 30% who agree, while 16% remain neutral. Only 3% disagree, and 1% strongly disagree. This means that 80% of respondents express a positive view regarding the influence of digital creators on lifestyle and spending behaviour.

This distribution indicates that digital creators are widely perceived as influential beyond mere entertainment, affecting daily habits and consumption choices. From a financial perspective, lifestyle influences are closely connected to spending patterns, which directly affect saving capacity and long-term financial planning. Overall, the findings highlight the significant role digital creators play in shaping financial behaviour indirectly through lifestyle modelling among young adults.

8. Income earned through digital content creation is subject to instability and irregularity.

Table and Chart 3.12

Strongly Disagree	0%
Disagree	9%
Neutral	24%
Agree	50%
Strongly Agree	17%
Total	100%



Source: Primary Data

Interpretation

The table and chart show the level of agreement that income earned through digital content creation is unstable and irregular. A majority of respondents agree at 50%, followed by 17% who strongly agree, 24% who remain neutral, and 9% who disagree. This clearly indicates that most respondents recognise income volatility as a key characteristic of digital creator careers.

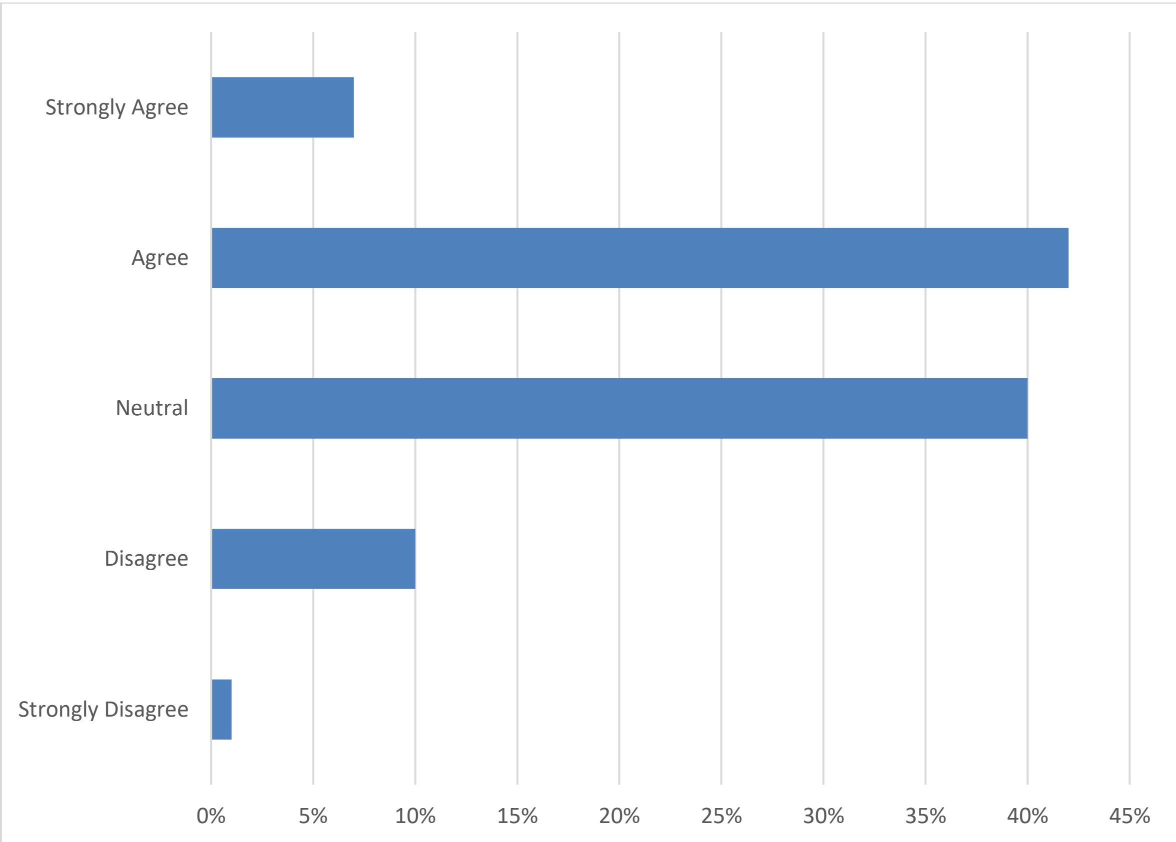
The presence of 24% neutral responses suggests that while awareness is high, a section of respondents may not have direct exposure or a complete understanding of how digital earnings fluctuate. However, the overall dominance of agreement reflects a realistic perception of irregular income patterns in the creator economy. Most respondents recognize the uncertain nature of creator earnings.

Overall, acknowledging income instability is important because irregular earnings require structured budgeting, savings discipline, and contingency planning. The limited disagreement further supports the idea that young adults understand the financial uncertainty associated with digital income models.

9. After watching financial content, I have changed how I save or spend money.

Table and Chart 3.13

Strongly Disagree	1%
Disagree	10%
Neutral	40%
Agree	42%
Strongly Agree	7%
Total	100%



Source: Primary Data

Interpretation

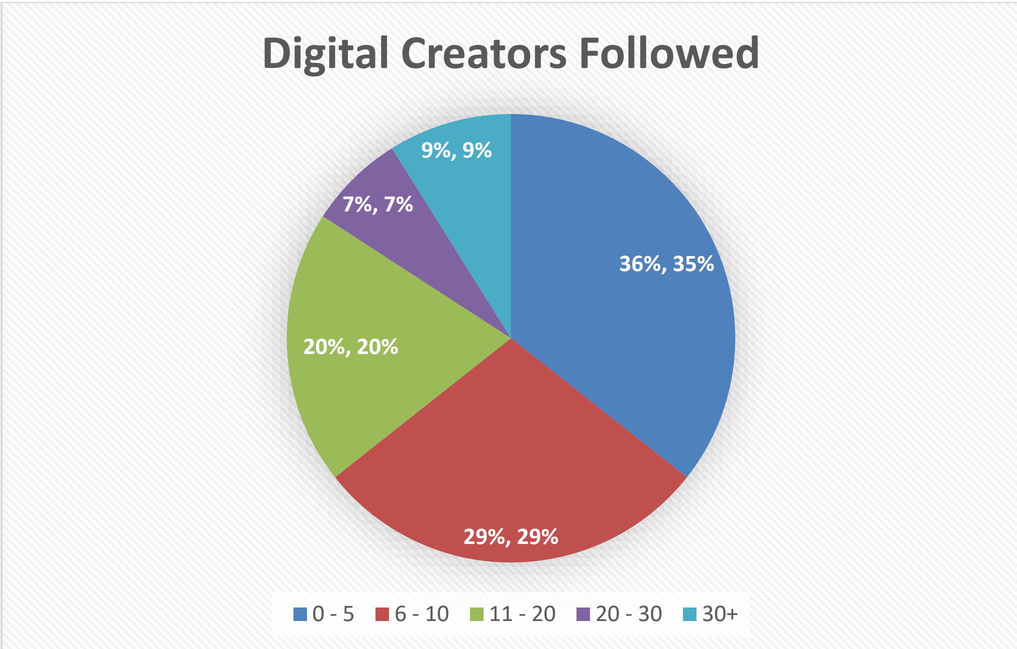
The bar chart examines the level of agreement on whether watching financial content has changed saving or spending behaviour. The highest proportion of responses falls under neutral at 40%, followed closely by agree at 37% and strongly agree at 7%. In contrast, 10% disagree, and only 1% strongly disagree.

This indicates that while not all respondents report a definite behavioural shift, a considerable proportion acknowledge some level of influence. The high neutral responses suggest that financial content may first create awareness, which gradually translates into behavioural change. From a finance perspective, the findings imply that digital financial content plays a meaningful role in shaping saving and spending patterns among young adults, with minimal outright rejection of its impact.

10. Number of digital creators followed across social media platforms.

Table and Chart 3.14

0- 5	36%
6-10	29%
11- 20	20%
20 - 30	7%
30+	9%
Total	100%



Source: Primary Data

Interpretation

The response pattern indicates active engagement with digital creators across social media platforms. The largest group of respondents follows between 0 to 5 creators at 36%, followed by 6 to 10 creators at 29%. This suggests that most young adults maintain a focused and selective engagement with creators rather than following an excessive number.

A further 20% follow between 11 to 20 creators, while 7% follow 20 to 30 creators, and 9% follow more than 30 creators. This shows that a notable segment of respondents is exposed to a wider range of digital content and perspectives.

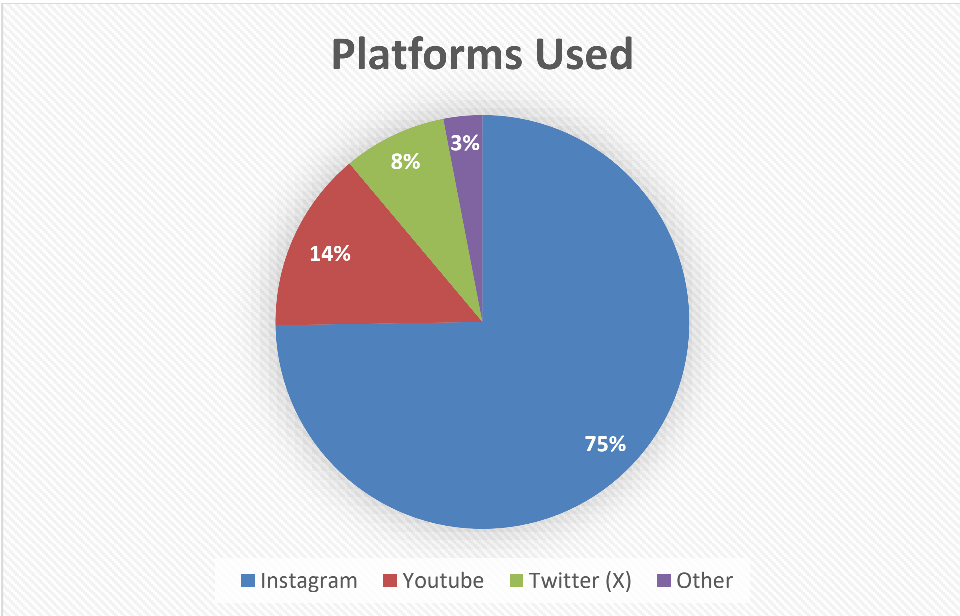
Respondents typically follow a moderate number of creators weekly.

Overall, the findings reflect meaningful engagement with digital creators, with many respondents engaging at levels sufficient to stay informed while maintaining balanced consumption habits. This pattern supports the idea that digital creators have consistent visibility among young adults.

11. Primary platform used to follow digital creators.

Table and Chart 3.15

Instagram	74%
Youtube	14%
Twitter (X)	8%
Other	3%
Total	100%



Source: Primary Data

Interpretation

he distribution of responses highlights Instagram as the dominant platform for following digital creators, with 74% of respondents indicating it as their primary choice. This clearly places Instagram at the center of creator-led content consumption among young adults.

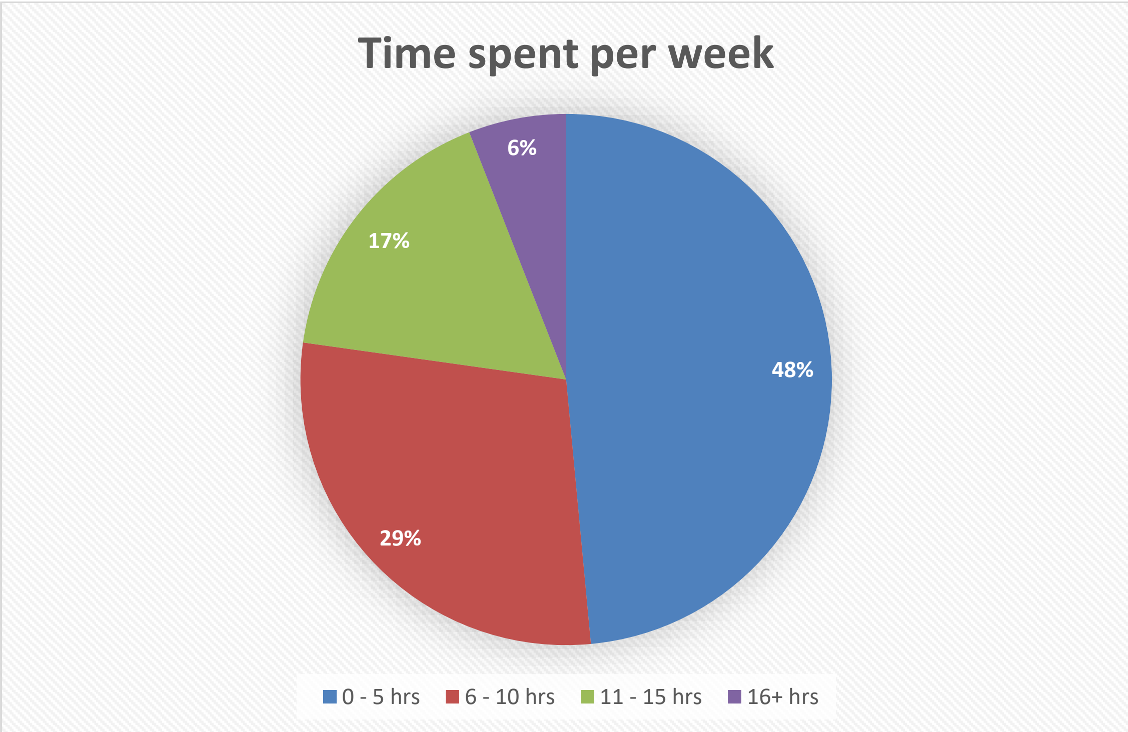
YouTube follows at 14%, while Twitter (X) accounts for 8%, reflecting a lower preference for platforms that rely on longer or text-heavy formats. Only 3 percent of respondents reported using other platforms, indicating limited platform diversification.

This trend reflects a strong preference for platforms that deliver content in a quick, visual, and engaging manner. The dominance of Instagram suggests that digital creators are more likely to influence awareness and behaviour when information is shared through easily accessible and short-format content rather than detailed or time-intensive platforms.

12. Average time spent per week consuming content created by digital creators.

Table and Chart 3.16

0 - 5 hrs	49%
6 - 10 hrs	29%
11 - 15 hrs	17%
16+ hrs	6%
Total	100%



Source: Primary Data

Interpretation

This pie chart shows the average time spent per week. The 0-5 hours category leads at 49%, followed by 6-10 hours at 20%, 11-15 hours at 17%, and 16+ hours at 6%, with about 7% possibly in lower or unshown ranges. Nearly half of the respondents spend minimal time weekly, while a smaller group goes beyond 10 hours.

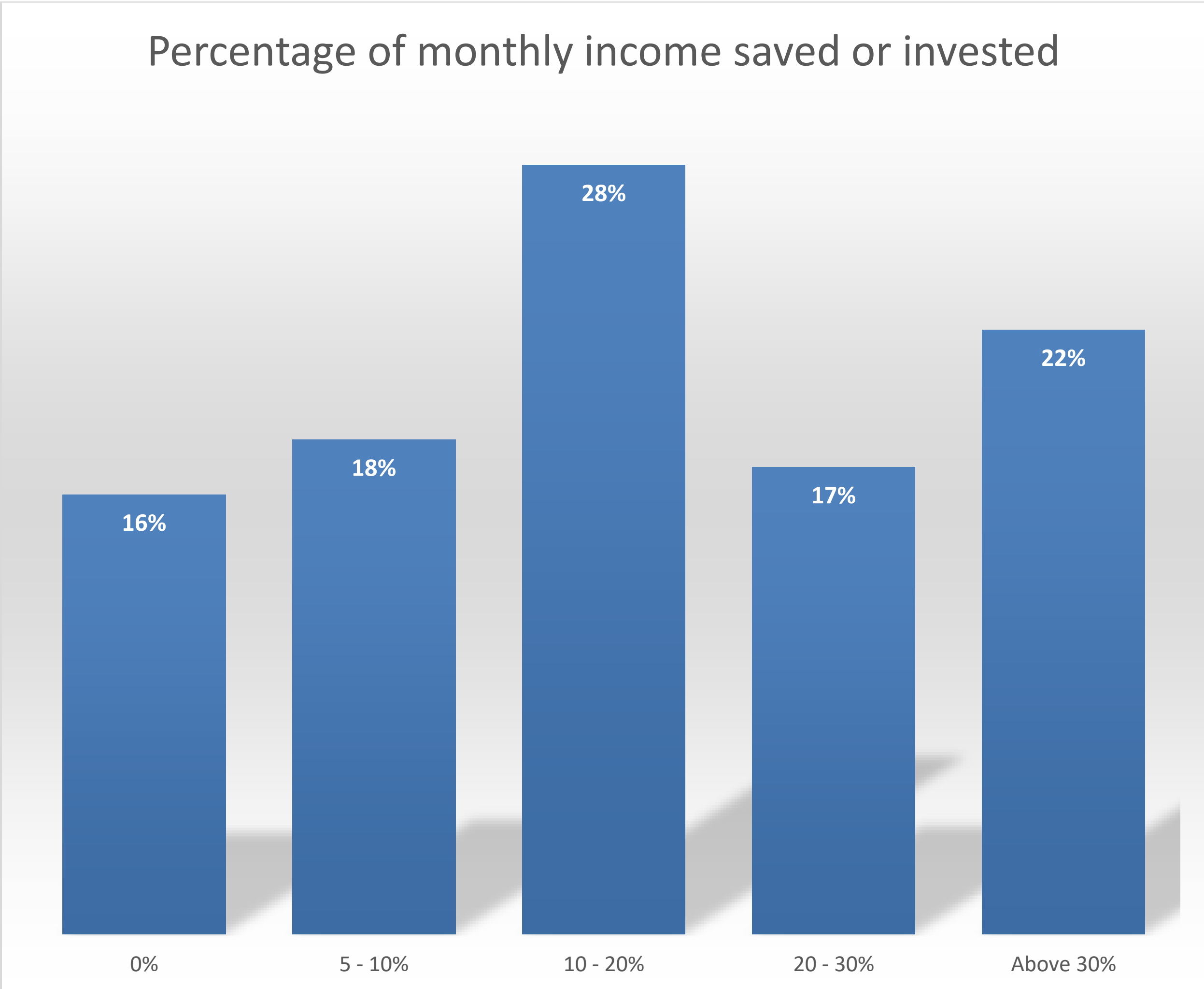
Although a majority does not spend extensive time on such content, this does not reduce its impact. Financial content consumed in concise formats such as short videos or posts can deliver key messages efficiently without requiring prolonged attention.

From a finance perspective, this indicates that the positive impact of digital creators lies more in the quality and relevance of content rather than the quantity of time spent. Moderate exposure allows young adults to gain financial insights without overdependence, supporting informed financial behavior while maintaining independent decision-making.

13. Share of monthly income allocated or planned towards savings and investments.

Table and Chart 3.17

0%	16%
5 - 10%	18%
10 - 20%	28%
20 - 30%	17%
Above 30%	22%
Total	100%



Source: Primary Data

Interpretation

The bar chart shows the percentage of monthly income allocated or planned towards savings and investments. The highest proportion of respondents allocate 10% to 20% of their income at 28%, followed by those allocating above 30% at 22%. This indicates that most young adults prefer setting aside a moderate portion of their income rather than extreme levels of saving or complete non-allocation.

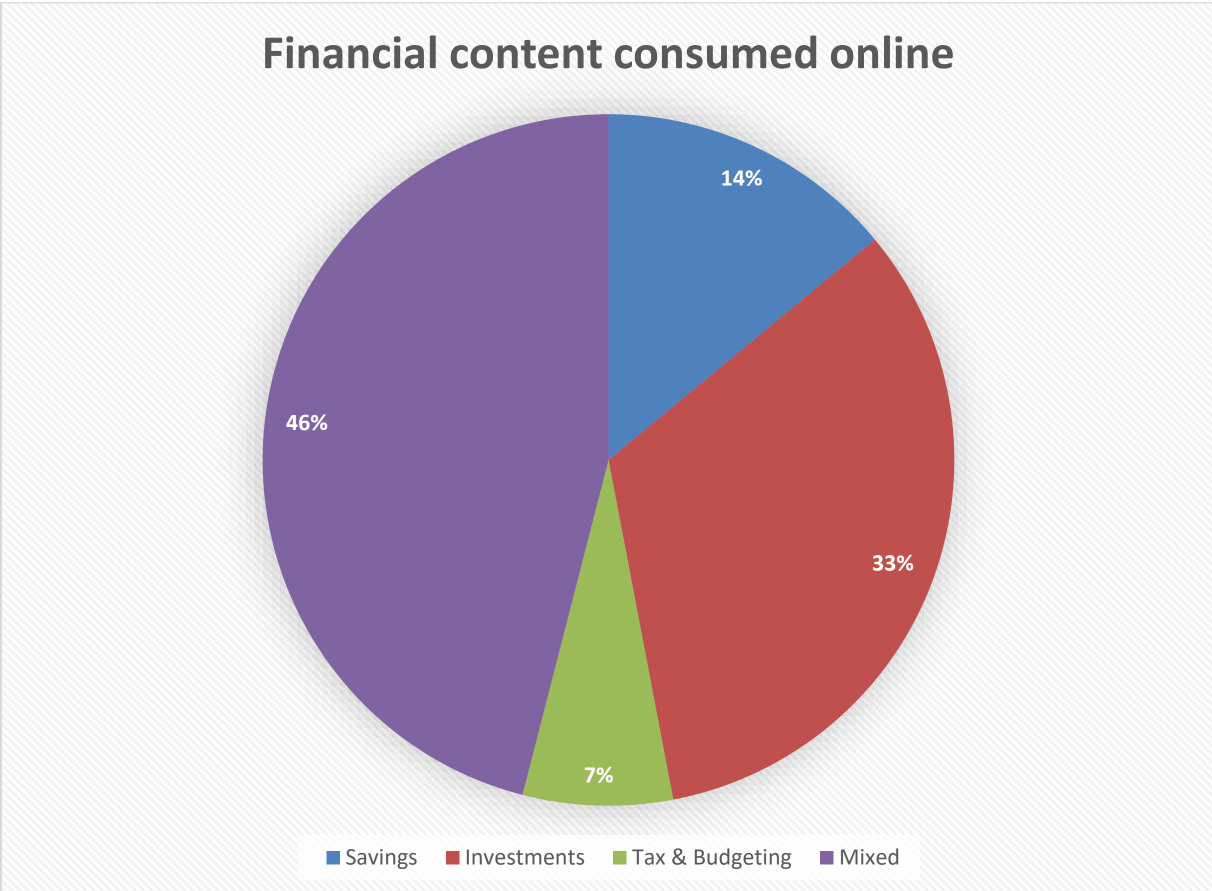
A further 18% allocate between 5% to 10% of their income, while 17% allocate between 20% to 30%, showing steady and planned saving behaviour across different income levels. However, 16 percent report no allocation towards savings or investments, suggesting that a section of respondents may face financial constraints or lack structured saving habits.

Overall, it indicates young adults practice steady saving habits influenced by creators, with over two-thirds committing 5% or more monthly. This reflects growing financial discipline and ties to my objectives on spending behaviors and investment patterns amid diverse influencer incomes. Low 0% allocation suggests creators motivate action over inaction.

14. Preferred type of financial content consumed online.

Table and Chart 3.18

Savings	14%
Investments	33%
Tax & Budgeting	7%
Mixed	46%
Total	100%



Source: Primary Data

Interpretation

The table and pie chart show the preferred type of financial content consumed online by respondents. Mixed financial content forms the largest share at 46 percent, indicating that most respondents prefer content that covers multiple aspects, such as savings, investments, and budgeting together, rather than focusing on a single topic.

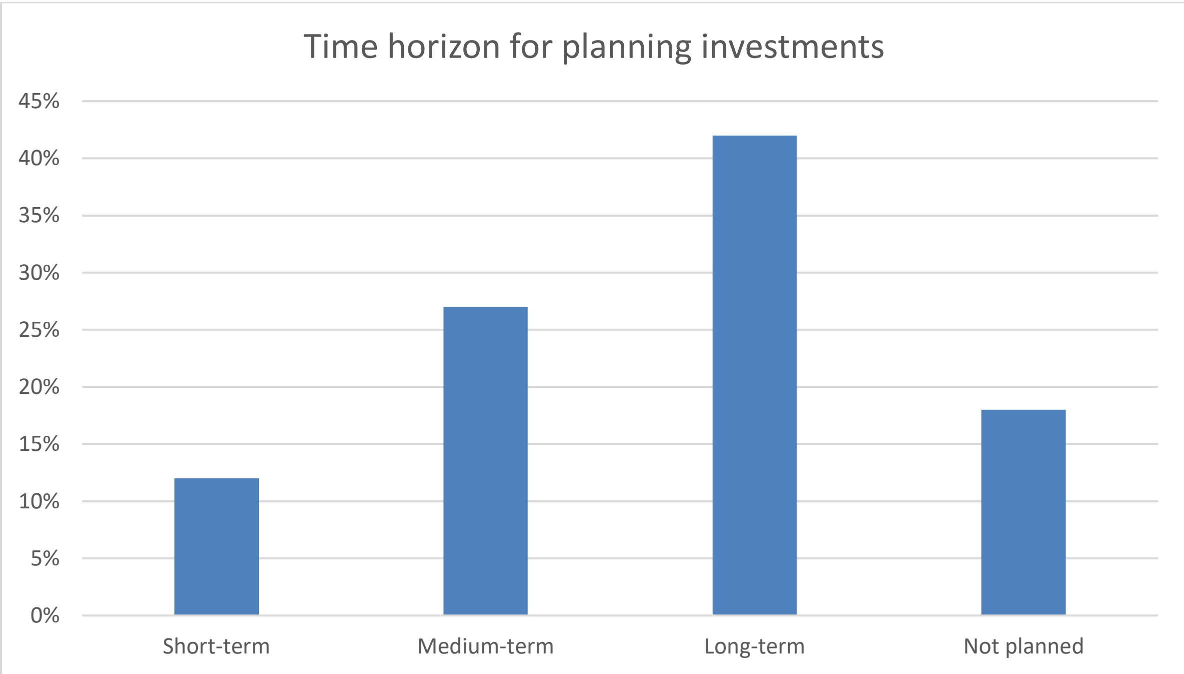
Investment-related content follows at 33 percent, showing strong interest in understanding investment opportunities and market-related information. Savings-focused content accounts for 14 percent, suggesting moderate attention towards basic saving practices, while tax and budgeting content remains the least preferred at 7 percent.

Overall, the findings indicate that young adults prefer a holistic approach to financial learning rather than isolated financial topics. From a finance perspective, this suggests that digital financial content plays an important role in shaping well-rounded financial awareness, while also highlighting the need for greater emphasis on tax planning and budgeting knowledge among young individuals.

15. Time horizon considered while planning investments.

Table and Chart 3.19

Short-term	12%
Medium-term	27%
Long-term	42%
Not planned	18%
Total	100%



Source: Primary Data

Interpretation

The table and chart show the time horizon considered by respondents while planning investments. Long-term planning leads at 42%, followed by medium-term planning at 27%, indicating that a majority of respondents focus on sustained financial growth rather than short-term returns.

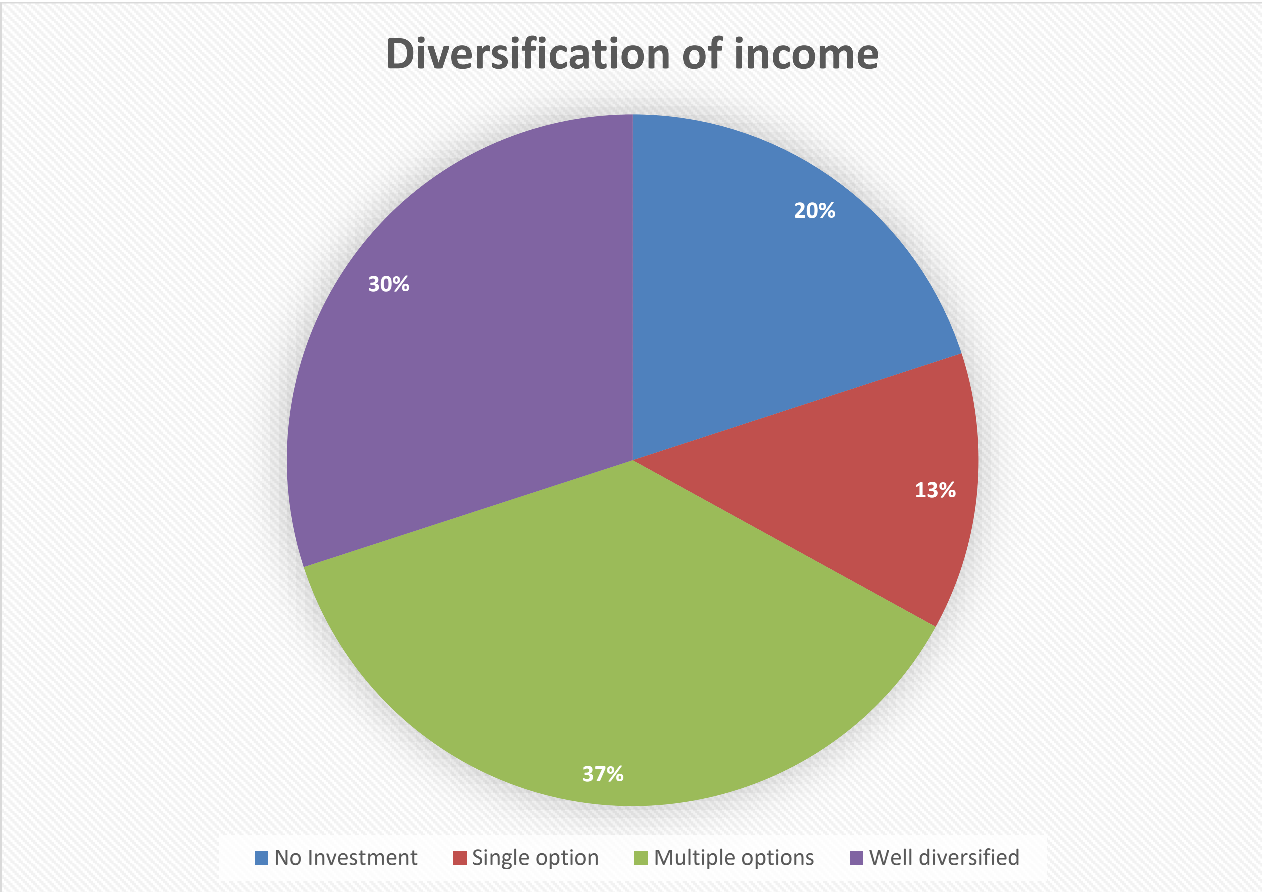
Short-term investment planning remains limited at 12%, suggesting low preference for quick-return strategies. At the same time, 18% of respondents report that their investments are not planned, highlighting that a section of young adults still lacks structured investment planning.

Overall, the findings indicate a growing inclination towards long- and medium-term investment horizons among young adults. From a finance perspective, this reflects increasing financial maturity and risk awareness, while also suggesting the influence of digital financial content in encouraging patient and goal-oriented investment strategies.

16. Level of diversification in personal investments.

Table and Chart 3.20

No Investment	20%
Single option	13%
Multiple options	37%
Well diversified	30%
Total	100%



Source: Primary Data

Interpretation

The pie chart illustrates the level of diversification in personal investments among respondents. Investments across multiple options form the largest share at 37%, followed by well-diversified investments at 30%. This indicates that a majority of respondents prefer spreading their investments across different avenues rather than concentrating on a single option, reflecting awareness of risk management.

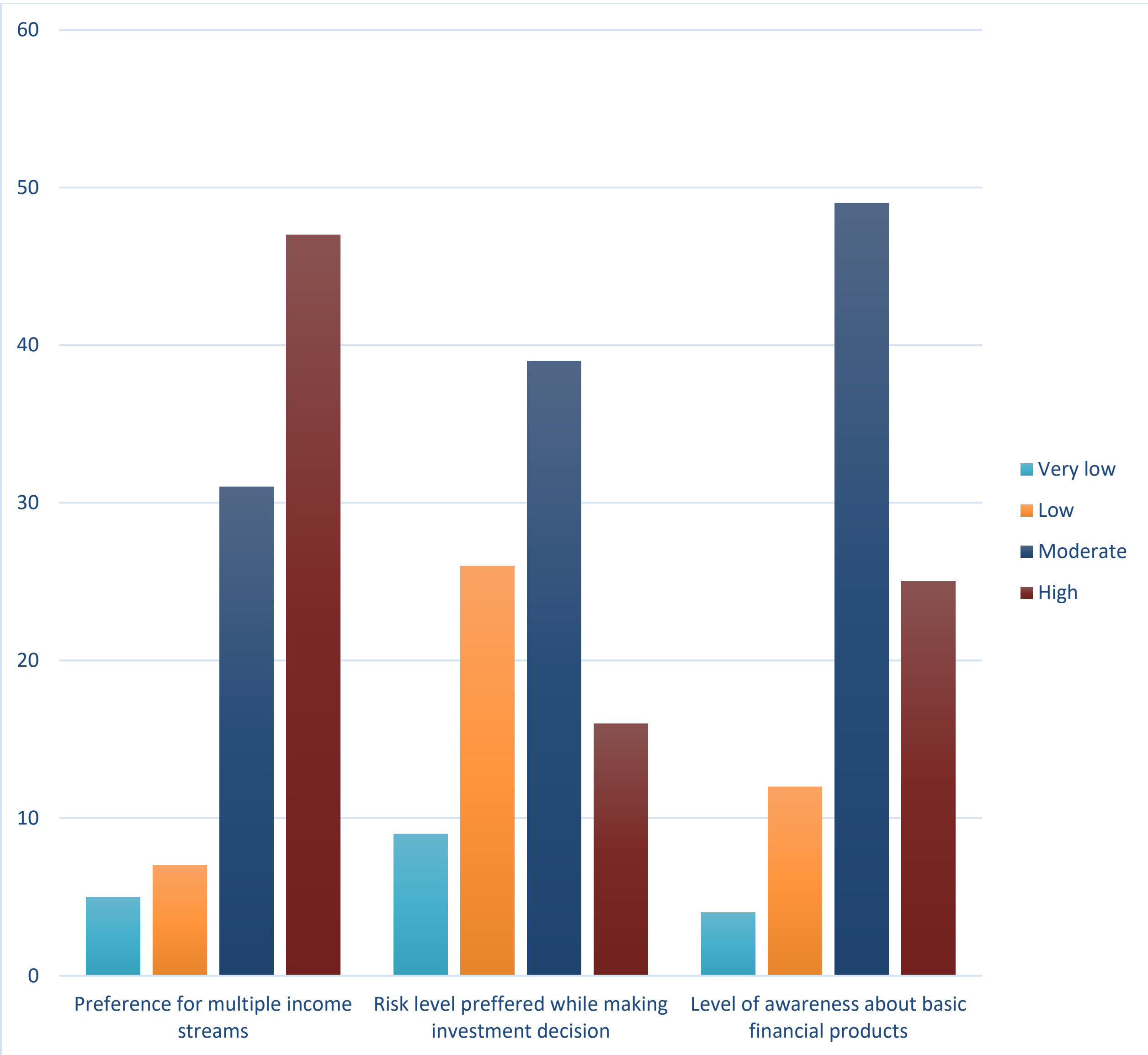
At the same time, 20% of respondents report having no investments, suggesting that a noticeable section of young adults has not yet entered the investment market. Single-option investments account for 13%, indicating limited diversification among a smaller group with lower exposure to investment opportunities.

Overall, 67% of respondents follow either multiple or well-diversified investment approaches, which is significantly higher than those with no investments. From a finance perspective, this shows a growing preference for diversification and long-term stability, reflecting improving investment maturity influenced by creators' guidance.

17. Please indicate your preference or level in relation to the following financial aspects.

Table and Chart 3.21

Particulars	Very low	Low	Moderate	High
Preference for multiple income streams	5	7	31	47
Risk level preferred while making investment decision	9	26	39	16
Level of awareness about basic financial products	4	12	49	25



Source: Primary Data

Interpretation

The table and chart show clear differences in respondents preferences across key financial aspects. A strong preference for multiple income streams is evident, with high responses at 47 and moderate responses at 31, while low and very low responses remain minimal. This indicates that young adults place strong importance on income diversification, reflecting awareness of income uncertainty and the need for financial stability. Preferences stay cautious here.

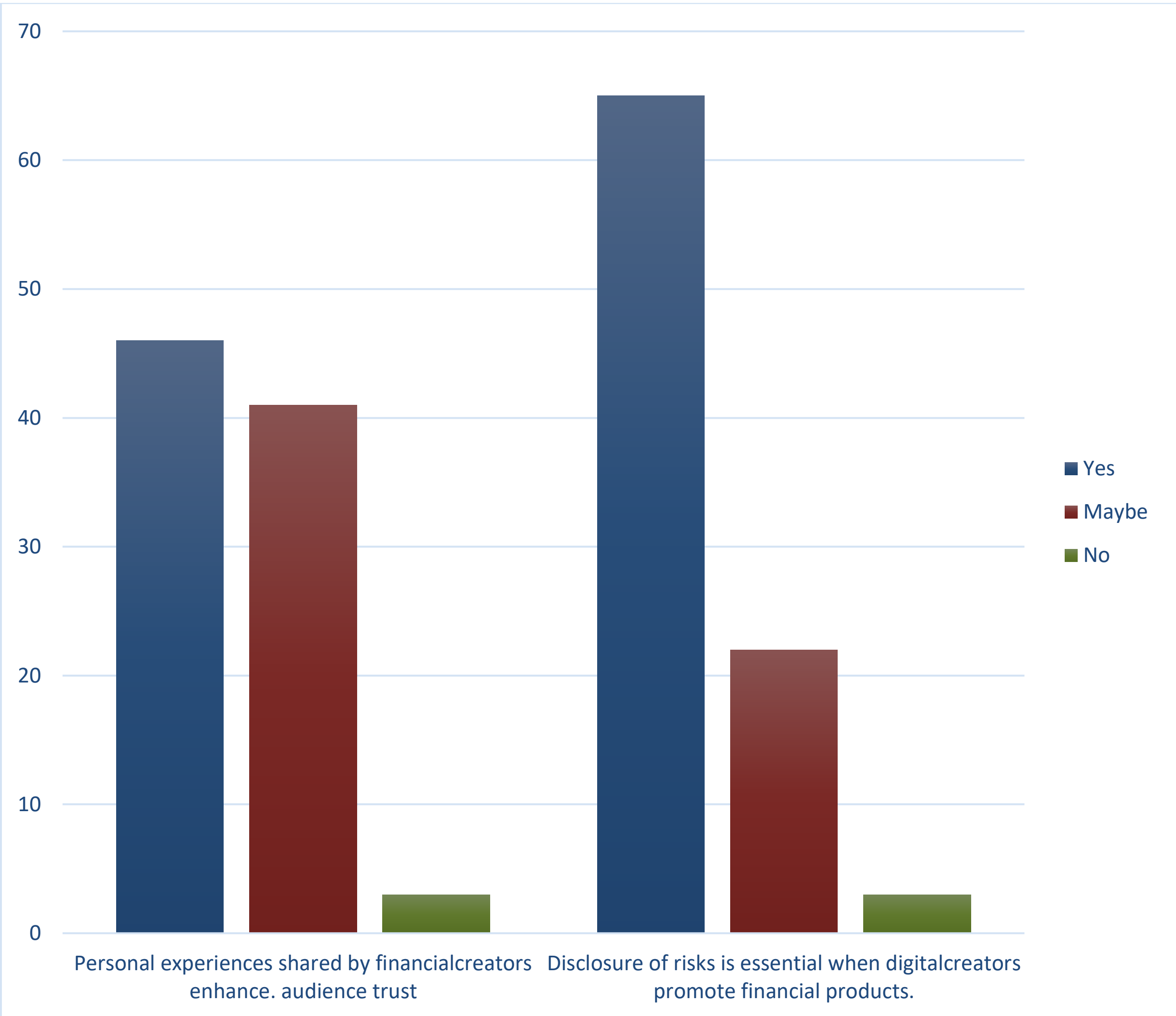
With respect to risk preference while making investment decisions, most responses fall under the moderate category at 39, followed by low at 26, while fewer respondents indicate high risk preference. This suggests a cautious approach to investing, where respondents prefer controlled and balanced risk rather than aggressive decision-making.

In terms of awareness about basic financial products, responses are largely concentrated at moderate and high levels, indicating a reasonable level of financial understanding. However, the presence of lower awareness responses suggests that while general financial habits are developing, deeper knowledge of financial products may still require improvement. Overall, the findings indicate that digital influence encourages broad financial habits such as diversification, while detailed risk understanding and product knowledge develop at a more gradual pace.

18. Please indicate your level of agreement with the following statements.

Table and Chart 3.22

Particulars	Yes	Maybe	No
Personal experiences shared by financial creators enhance. audience trust	46	41	3
Disclosure of risks is essential when digital creators promote financial products.	65	22	3



Source: Primary Data

Interpretation

The chart shows a strong link between trust and the behaviour of financial creators. Most respondents agreed that personal experiences shared by creators build trust, with 46 selecting yes and 41 selecting maybe, while only 3 disagreed. This indicates that real-life experiences help create credibility, but many respondents remain cautious and prefer to assess such content before fully relying on it.

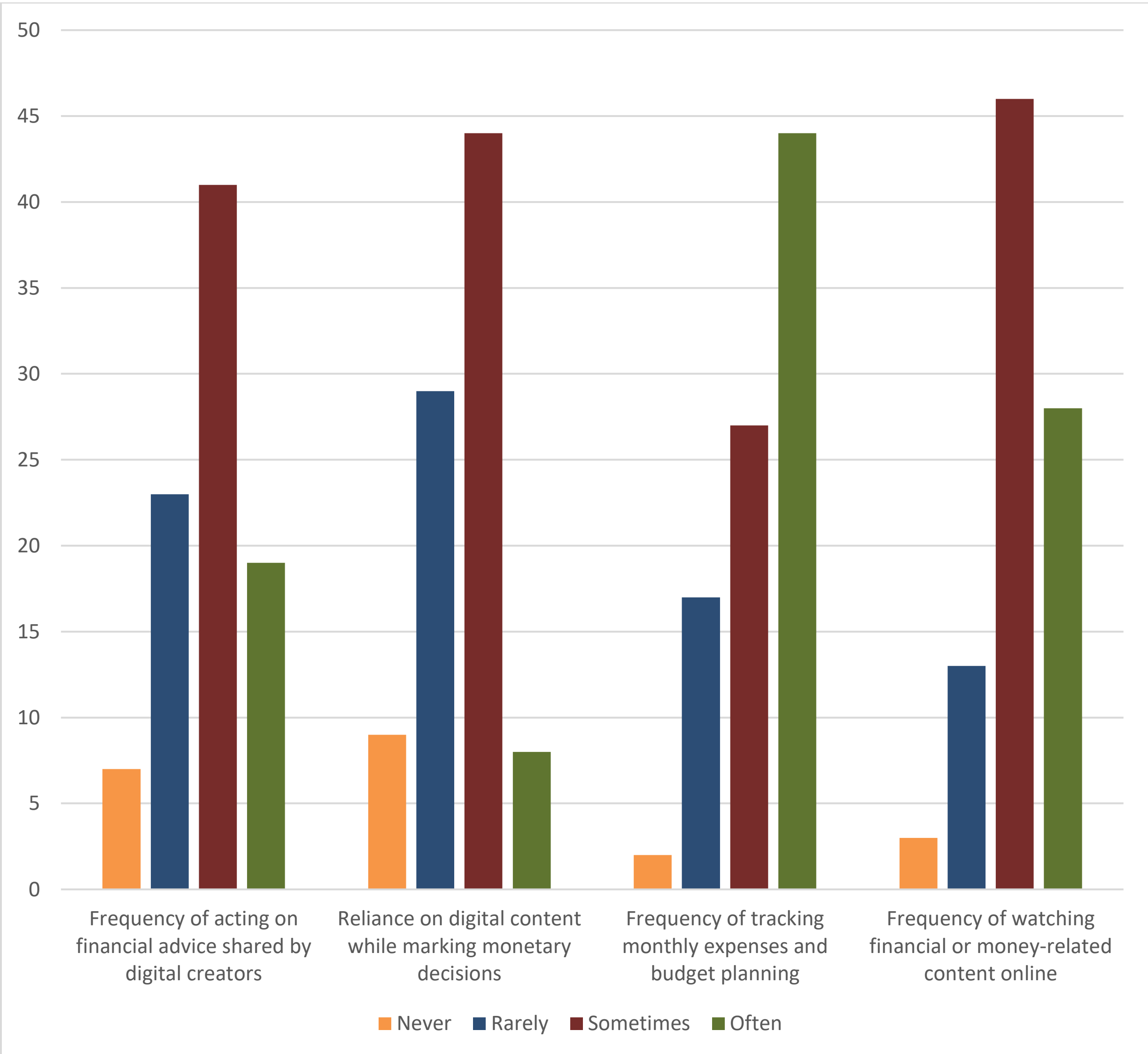
Opinions are clearer when it comes to risk disclosure in financial promotions. A large majority agreed that disclosure of risks is essential, with 65 respondents selecting yes, followed by 22 selecting maybe, and only 3 selecting no. This indicates strong awareness of transparency and ethical responsibility in financial communication. From a finance perspective, the findings suggest that young adults value honest risk communication and consider it important for making informed investment decisions.

Overall, these responses indicate that while trust in financial creators is influenced by personal connection and relatability, it is ultimately strengthened by transparency and ethical behaviour. The strong agreement on risk disclosure highlights a financially aware audience that values responsible communication over promotional influence, aligning closely with the study's focus on financial awareness and informed investment behaviour among young adults.

19. Please indicate the frequency of the following financial behaviours.

Table and Chart 3.23

Particulars	Never	Rarely	Sometimes	Often
Frequency of acting on financial advice shared by digital creators	7	23	41	19
Reliance on digital content while making monetary decisions	9	29	44	8
Frequency of tracking monthly expenses and budget planning	2	17	27	44
Frequency of watching financial or money-related content online	3	13	46	28



Source: Primary Data

Interpretation

The chart shows varying levels of engagement across four financial behaviors among digital creators and influencers. Sharing financial advice is reported sometimes by 23 respondents and often by 15 respondents, while only 7 indicate rarely and 3 indicate never. Tracking company finances shows stronger involvement, with 28 respondents selecting often and 17 selecting sometimes, and very few indicating rarely or never. Watching financial or money-related content records the highest engagement, with 46 respondents watching often and 33 watching sometimes, whereas rarely and never remain comparatively low. Sharing money-related content displays a slightly mixed pattern, where it often remains high at 44 responses, but rarely rises to 17, indicating lower consistency in sharing compared to consumption.

These patterns indicate that digital creators and influencers are actively engaged with financial information, particularly in consuming content and managing business finances. However, the comparatively lower consistency in sharing money-related content suggests that creators may be selective due to audience preferences, content strategy, or income-related considerations. Overall, the data reflects strong financial awareness and monitoring behavior, supporting the study’s focus on income diversity and evolving financial habits in the digital creator ecosystem.

CHAPTER 4

FINDINGS, CONCLUSION, AND SUGGESTIONS

CHAPTER 4

Findings, Conclusion, and Suggestions

4.1 Introduction

- The growth of social media has led to the rise of digital creators and finfluencers. They share financial content related to saving, investing, and budgeting. Their influence among young adults has increased significantly. As a result, digital platforms are becoming important sources of financial information.
- Financial topics are now discussed widely through online content. Complex concepts are often simplified for better understanding. This makes financial knowledge more accessible to young audiences. Social media is gradually supporting traditional financial learning.
- The increasing exposure to digital financial content may affect financial behaviour. Young adults regularly engage with such content. Understanding this influence is important for long-term financial planning. Therefore, this study examines its impact on financial awareness and investment behaviour.

4.2 Objectives

- To study the role of digital creators and finfluencers in enhancing financial awareness among young adults.
- To examine how exposure to online financial content influences savings and spending behaviour.

4.3 Research Methodology

- The present study is descriptive and analytical in nature. It aims to examine the influence of digital creators and finfluencers on the financial awareness and investment behaviour of young adults.
- Primary data has been collected through a structured questionnaire prepared using Google Forms. The questionnaire consisted of closed-ended questions based on likert scale and percentage-based responses to ensure clarity and ease of analysis.
- The respondents of the study include students, working professionals, and self-employed individuals, mainly within the young adult age group. A total of responses were collected and analysed using percentage distribution, tables, and charts.
- Secondary data has been gathered from research articles, journals, reports, and credible online sources to support the theoretical framework of the study.

4.4 Findings of the Study

- The study highlights the growing influence of digital creators and finfluencers on the financial awareness and behavioural patterns of young adults. A significant proportion of respondents perceive social media content as more effective than traditional learning sources in improving financial awareness. The majority agreed that financial concepts are simplified by finfluencers, making complex topics such as investing, budgeting, and risk management easier to understand. This indicates that digital platforms are becoming important informal channels of financial education, particularly among younger audiences.

- The findings further reveal that digital creators play a notable role in shaping lifestyle and consumption patterns. A large majority of respondents agreed that creators influence daily habits and spending behaviour. Since lifestyle choices directly impact saving capacity and investment potential, this suggests that digital influence extends beyond content consumption and affects actual financial behaviour. The strong positive responses indicate that digital creators indirectly shape financial decisions through lifestyle modelling.

- In relation to saving and investment habits, the study shows that finfluencers are widely perceived as encouraging early financial discipline. A substantial proportion of respondents agreed that online financial content motivates them to begin saving and investing at an early stage. This reflects a positive shift toward long-term financial planning and wealth creation among young adults. The findings suggest that exposure to digital financial content contributes to the development of structured saving behaviour and investment awareness.

- The data also indicates that more than half of the respondents acknowledge that digital creators have influenced their investment decisions either directly or indirectly. Although a notable percentage remained neutral, the overall trend suggests that digital financial content plays a supporting role in shaping investment preferences. Investment decisions are typically influenced by multiple factors, including risk perception, financial knowledge, and personal goals; however, digital creators appear to contribute meaningfully to the awareness and evaluation stage of decision-making.

- Another important finding relates to income perception within the digital creator economy. A majority of respondents recognise that income earned through digital content creation is unstable and irregular. This awareness reflects a realistic understanding of income volatility associated with sponsorships, advertisements, and platform-based earnings. From a financial standpoint, recognition of such instability underscores the importance of financial planning, emergency funds, and diversified income sources.

- In terms of financial behaviour patterns, respondents demonstrate a strong preference for income diversification. A majority express high or moderate preference for multiple income streams, indicating awareness of income risk management. Similarly, investment diversification is widely adopted, with a significant proportion investing across multiple options or maintaining well-diversified portfolios. This reflects a growing understanding of risk distribution and long-term financial stability.

- The allocation of monthly income toward savings and investments further supports the presence of financial discipline. Most respondents allocate between 5 to 20 percent or more of their income towards savings and investments, indicating structured financial behaviour. Additionally, the majority plan investments with medium- to long-term horizons, suggesting focus on sustained wealth creation rather than short-term gains.

- Content consumption patterns show that most respondents spend a moderate amount of time engaging with digital creator content. Although time spent per week is generally limited, regular exposure appears sufficient to influence awareness and financial attitudes. Preference for mixed financial content and investment-related topics indicates demand for comprehensive and practical financial information rather than isolated financial subjects.

- Demographic analysis strengthens the credibility of the study. The majority of respondents fall within the 18 to 25 age group, aligning with the study’s focus on young adults. Gender representation is relatively balanced, and respondents belong to varied income and occupational categories. This diversity supports broader generalisation of findings across different earning capacities and employment statuses.

- Overall, the study finds that digital creators and finfluencers have a meaningful and measurable influence on financial awareness, saving habits, investment preferences, lifestyle-driven consumption behaviour, and income perception among young adults. While digital influence may not be the sole determinant of financial decision-making, it plays a significant supportive role in shaping financial attitudes and encouraging structured financial behaviour.

4.5 Conclusion of the Study

The present study concludes that digital creators and finfluencers have emerged as influential contributors to financial awareness and behavioural development among young adults. In an environment where social media forms a significant part of daily life, financial content shared through digital platforms is not only consumed widely but also perceived as relatable and accessible. The findings clearly indicate that young adults view digital financial content as an effective medium for understanding financial concepts when compared to traditional learning sources.

The study establishes that digital influence extends beyond passive information sharing and contributes to actual financial behaviour. A substantial proportion of respondents recognise that social media content affects their saving and spending habits, and many acknowledge its role in shaping investment decisions either directly or indirectly. The encouragement of early savings and investment habits further reflects the constructive role played by finfluencers in promoting financial discipline at a young age.

Another important conclusion drawn from the study is the awareness of income volatility within the digital creator economy. Respondents largely recognise that income earned through digital content creation is irregular and unstable. This understanding highlights the importance of structured financial planning, emergency fund creation, and income diversification. The preference for multiple income streams and diversified investment strategies indicates that young adults are developing a practical approach toward risk management and long-term financial stability.

The findings also reveal a shift in communication preference. Engagement with digital creators is often perceived as more relatable than interaction with formal financial institutions. This relatability appears to enhance trust and information acceptance, thereby influencing financial awareness and behavioural outcomes. However, the presence of neutral responses across several variables suggests that digital influence is supportive rather than absolute, and traditional financial institutions continue to hold relevance.

Overall, the study concludes that, while digital creators may not function as formal financial advisors, their accessibility, simplified communication style, and lifestyle modelling contribute significantly to contemporary financial awareness and behavioural formation. The study therefore recognises digital creators as important participants in the evolving landscape of financial education and behavioural finance.

4.6 Suggestions and Recommendations

Based on the findings of the study, several suggestions can be proposed to enhance the positive role of digital creators in financial awareness and behavioural development.

- Firstly, digital creators and finfluencers should ensure responsible and transparent communication, especially while promoting financial products. Since a majority of respondents recognise income instability and value risk disclosure, creators must clearly communicate potential risks along with benefits. Transparent financial communication will strengthen credibility and reduce the possibility of misleading financial decisions.

- Secondly, there is a need to promote deeper financial literacy alongside simplified content. While respondents appreciate simplified explanations, structured content on topics such as risk assessment, diversification strategies, tax planning, and long-term investment planning should be encouraged. This will help convert awareness into informed and rational financial decision-making.

- Thirdly, financial institutions and banks should adapt their communication strategies to become more relatable and accessible to young audiences. Since many respondents perceive digital creators as more approachable than formal institutions, traditional financial bodies can collaborate with credible creators to deliver accurate and simplified financial education.

- Fourthly, Young adults should critically evaluate digital financial content before acting on it. Investment decisions should be supported by proper research and financial knowledge to avoid impulsive behaviour.

- Fifthly, policymakers and regulatory authorities should establish clearer guidelines for financial promotions on digital platforms. As finfluencers increasingly shape financial attitudes, regulatory oversight can ensure ethical promotion of financial products and protect young investors from misinformation.

- Finally, educational institutions can integrate practical financial education into academic curricula. Since the majority of respondents belong to the young adult age group, structured financial training at an early stage can strengthen saving habits, investment planning, and long-term financial discipline.

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ANNEXURE

ANNEXURE

SECTION - 1

Age

- o Below 18
- o 18 – 25
- o 26 – 35
- o 36 – 45
- o Above 45

Gender

- o Male
- o Female

Occupation

- o Student
- o Working Professional
- o Self – Employed
- o Other

Monthly Income

- o ₹10,000 - ₹20,000
- o ₹20,000 - ₹40,000
- o ₹40,000 - ₹60,000
- o ₹60,000 - ₹80,000
- o Above ₹80,000

1. Social media content influences financial awareness more effectively than traditional learning sources.

- o Strongly disagree
- o Disagree
- o Neutral
- o Agree
- o Strongly Agree

2. Finfluencers simplify complex financial topics for young audience.
- Strongly disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

3. Finfluencers encourage early savings and investment habits.
- Strongly disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

4. Digital creators have influenced my investment decisions directly or indirectly.
- Strongly disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

5. Content created on social media platforms affects spending and saving behaviour.
- Strongly disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

6. Engagement with digital creators feels more relatable than interaction with formal financial institutions.

- Strongly disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

7. Digital creators play a significant role in shaping lifestyle and consumption patterns among young adults.

- Strongly disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

8. Income earned through digital content creation is subject to instability and irregularity.

- Strongly disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

9. After watching financial content, I have changed how I save or spend money.

- Strongly disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

SECTION – 2

1. Number of digital creators followed across social media platforms.
   - 0 – 5
   - 6 – 10
   - 11- 20
   - 20 – 30
   - 30+

2. Primary platform used to follow digital creators.
   - Instagram
   - Youtube
   - Twitter (X)
   - Other
3. Average time spent per week consuming content created by digital creators.
   - 0 - 5hrs
   - 6 - 10hrs
   - 11 - 15hrs
   - 16+

4. Share of monthly income allocated or planned towards savings and investments.
   - 0%
   - 5 - 10%
   - 10 - 20%
   - 20 - 30%
   - Above 30%

5. Preferred type of financial content consumed online.
   - Savings
   - Investments
   - Tax & Budgeting
   - Mixed

6. Time horizon considered while planning investments.
- Short-term
- Medium-term
- Long-term
- Not planned

7. Level of diversification in personal investments.
- No investment
- Single option
- Multiple options
- Well diversified

8. Please indicate your preference or level in relation to the following financial aspects.

	Very Low	Low	Moderate	High
Preference for multiple income streams.	o	o	o	o
Risk level preferred while making investment decisions.	o	o	o	o
Level of awareness about basic financial products	o	o	o	o

9. Please indicate your level of agreement with the following statements.

	Yes	No	Maybe
Personal experiences shared by financial creators enhance audience trust	○	○	○
Disclosure of risks is essential when digital creators promote financial products.	○	○	○

10. Please indicate the frequency of the following financial behaviors.

	Never	Rarely	Sometimes	Often
Frequency of acting on financial advice shared by digital creators	○	○	○	○
Reliance on digital financial content while making monetary decisions.	○	○	○	○
Frequency of tracking monthly expenses and budget planning	○	○	○	○
Frequency of watching financial or money-related content online	○	○	○	○